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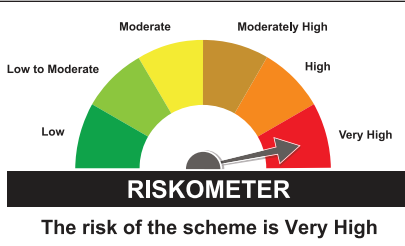


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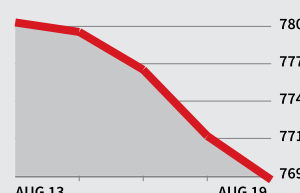
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Mutual Fund investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.

CM
YK

the hindu businessline

SENSEX 76909.68 (-325.78)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	24078.30	-76.60
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.37	-0.09
US Dollar (in ₹)	95.75	+0.08
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	153252.00	-211
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	229225.00	-3939

MONSOON MAYHEM.

Depression lingers over Jharkhand, extending widespread rainfall across North and North-East India **p8**



BONANZA.

Indian women set to inherit ₹73 lakh crore, but only 23% have a wealth transfer plan **p10**

QUICKLY.

COMPREHENSIVE REVIEW
‘SEBI working on easing SME listing framework’



Mumbai: The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) is working on a comprehensive review of the small and medium enterprise (SME) listing framework to address difficulties with the existing rules related to trading, migration to the mainboard, market-making and underwriting. **p6**

TRANSPORT ECONOMICS
Cabinet approves five projects worth ₹13,041 cr

New Delhi: The Union Cabinet on Wednesday approved five projects, including four for the Railways and another for the highways, together worth ₹13,041 crore, with Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw emphasising that the government’s focus on expanding the rail network is backed by transport economics. **p3**

Copthall, Mansi Share barred for Sensex CAS manipulation

QUESTIONABLE OPTIONS. SEBI impounds ₹3.68 cr as their orders benefited them unfairly

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

SEBI has cracked down on two entities after finding *prima facie* evidence of manipulation in last week’s Sensex expiry close during the newly-introduced Closing Auction Session (CAS) by placing aggressive buy and sell orders.

The markets regulator restrained Copthall Mauritius Investment and Mansi Share and Stock Broking from accessing the securities market, and closing auction. Copthall was ordered to disgorge ₹2.96 crore and Mansi ₹71.65 lakh. Their bank accounts are also directed to be frozen for debits.

During the CAS on August 13, the Sensex swung 362.02 points in just two seconds, 132.67 points in 12 seconds and another 405.08 points in 28 seconds, with all three sharp moves unfolding within five minutes.

Copthall was buying across Sensex constituents and at prices close to the upper permissible limit. It ac-

The impact

Time (pm)	Duration	Sensex IEP move (points)	Copthall share of buy orders (%)
3:20:41 - 3:20:43	2 sec	+362.02	99.91
3:24:08 - 3:24:20	12 sec	+132.67	96.09
3:25:49 - 3:26:17	28 sec	+405.08	85.21

counted for 99.91 per cent of the buy-order value during the first move, 96.09 per cent in the second and 85.21 per cent during the third. After the third spike, it cancelled buy orders worth about ₹98.12 crore across 30 stocks.

LONG POSITIONS

The significance of these trades becomes clearer when viewed alongside Copthall’s derivatives positions. SEBI found that the entity held substantial long call and short put positions in expiring Sensex options. A higher settlement value directly improved the profitability of those positions and reduced obligations arising from sold put options.

“It is *prima facie* established that such aggressive

buy orders by Copthall had caused a sustained upward move in IEP of Sensex constituents and ultimately resulted in Sensex closing at 78,080, whereas equivalent move based on Nifty movement would have resulted in Sensex closing at 77,840,” SEBI Whole-Time Member Kamlesh Varshney said in an *ex parte* interim order on Wednesday.

DIFFERENT STRATEGY

In contrast, Mansi Share and Stock Broking allegedly employed the opposite strategy. SEBI’s analysis shows that the broker’s proprietary account placed large sell orders worth more than ₹145.65 crore across several Sensex stocks at prices significantly below prevailing reference levels. These orders re-

mained in the system for nearly five minutes, exerting downward pressure on the index. Moments before the close, the orders were cancelled, triggering an immediate rebound in the IEP.

It placed sell orders worth ₹145.65 crore between 3.21 pm and 3.26 pm, and then cancelled ₹143.44 crore of those orders, which led to an immediate surge of 232.96 points in Sensex.

SEBI contends that these orders were never intended to result in genuine trades and were instead used to suppress the index while the firm exited profitable put option positions. The regulator has calculated wrongful gains of about ₹71.65 lakh from this activity.

SEBI, however, has not alleged that the two entities acted together, but each appeared to have tried to create a favourable move in the Sensex for its own expiry-day options positions.

Copthall stood to benefit from a higher Sensex, while Mansi had put-option positions that benefited from a lower index.

MPC members prefer to ‘wait and watch’ on economy’s ‘hazy’ outlook

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Even as all six Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) members opted for a ‘wait and watch’ approach at their meeting earlier this month as the economy faces a ‘hazy’ outlook, some members, including Governor Sanjay Malhotra and Deputy Governor Poonam Gupta, sent out smoke signals that a rate hike is within the realm of possibility, going by their statements at the meeting.

Members unanimously voted to keep the policy repo rate unchanged at 5.25 per cent at the August 3-5 MPC meeting. They also continued with the ‘neutral’ monetary policy stance. They noted that the risks of higher food, fuel and other input prices translating into a broad-based increase in inflation persist.

Reserve Bank of India Governor Sanjay Malhotra said inflation is expected to taper from its peak in Q3 (October-December). So, this shock does not call for a monetary response to curtail demand as of now. The RBI released the minutes of the MPC meeting on Wednesday.



“Having said this, there are signs of a normalisation of inflation from its benign levels seen hitherto. The average inflation last year, when the policy rate was brought down to 5.25 per cent, was only 2 per cent. Not only has headline inflation already averaged 3.93 per cent this year, even core excluding precious metals is expected to converge to core inflation (CPI excluding food and fuel) in the last quarter of this financial year... This may suggest a recalibration of policy rate,” Malhotra said.

However, he underscored that he would prefer to wait for more certainty to emerge on the inflation trajectory in terms of the persistence of realised prints at these or higher levels, the forecast and the likely levels at which inflation may normalise and

settle for any recalibration of the policy rate.

NO EASING NOW

Noting that the growth outcome during the year may turn out to be somewhat better (6.7 per cent) than projected in the June policy (6.6 per cent), while inflation could be marginally lower (5 per cent vs 5.1 per cent), Deputy Governor Gupta said that the scope for any further easing does not seem to exist at the current juncture.

“Instead, given that the headline inflation is projected to peak to a level as high as 5.9 per cent in Q3 2026-27, a case for a hike may emerge during the course of the year,” she said.

Gupta believes that with uncertainty persisting on account of global developments and weather-related risks, the best course of action would be to wait and watch a bit more.

Indranil Bhattacharyya, Executive Director, RBI, emphasised that the shift in the distribution towards higher inflation numbers warrants careful vigil. One must look out for the extent of generalisation and risk of inflation expectations getting unanchored before contemplating any rate hike.

Even as Sahara refunds remain in limbo, SEBI sits on ₹21,505 cr cash

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

More than eight years after the capital market regulator started the process of refunding investors in the infamous Sahara case, SEBI is now sitting on a cash pile of ₹21,505 crore.

SEBI, in its latest annual report, said it has not made any refund during 2025-26. The balance in the Sahara refund account increased to about ₹16,379 crore as of March-end 2026 against ₹16,138 crore in FY25. The balance was against the principal liability of ₹25,781 crore, it said.

As of March-end, the total fund balance, including accrued interest in FDs across various nationalised banks, stood about ₹21,505 crore

A refund mechanism cannot continue indefinitely without a defined procedure for dormant or disputed claims, said an expert

after remitting ₹5,000 crore to the Central Registrar of Cooperative Societies for disbursing to the investors in schemes of Sahara Group of Co-operative Societies.

Both Sahara India Real Estate Corporation and Sahara Housing Investment Corporation have filed an application in the Supreme Court to sell the entire remaining asset to Adani Properties. In January, SEBI submitted its response before the court

emphasising that the sale of Sahara properties should be done in a transparent manner by providing opportunities for all interested purchasers and subject to the conditions mentioned by the court. Currently, the matter is pending before the top court, said SEBI.

Sonam Chandwani, Managing Partner, KS Legal & Associates, said the more pressing concern is the absence of a clear end point. A refund mechanism cannot realistically continue indefinitely without a defined procedure for dormant or disputed claims, she said.

DEFINITE ROADMAP

The court should require the authorities to publish a definite roadmap showing how long claims will remain open, how unresolved claims will

be dealt with and what will happen to the balance thereafter, she added.

The special enforcement cell was constituted by SEBI to implement the directions of the court to refund the amounts collected from investors of Sahara India Real Estate Corporation and Sahara Housing Investment Corporation. The activities of SEBI in this matter are monitored by Justice (retired) BN Agarwal, appointed by the top court.

In 2012, the Supreme Court ruled that the two Sahara Group companies illegally raised over ₹24,000 crore through optionally fully convertible debentures from 23 million investors, mostly from small towns, bypassing the market regulator’s rules and ordered refund with 15 per cent interest.

TECH KICK



BATTLE OF THE MACHINES. Humanoid robots by Unitree Robotics take part in a kickboxing bout during the 2026 World Robot Conference in Beijing. China kicked off the meet on Wednesday, with companies showcasing the country’s expanding robotics industry as it looks to move the technology beyond demonstrations into factories and real-world applications **REUTERS**

With Samsung hiking chipmaking prices, smartphone rates are likely to go up

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Samsung Electronics’ decision to increase chipmaking service prices by up to 15 per cent for new orders is likely to impact smartphone prices in India, experts told *businessline*.

Smartphone sales went down for three consecutive weeks after Amazon Prime Day and Flipkart’s GOAT sale in July. Prices across entry-level smartphones have risen steadily over three months.

Samsung recorded the sharpest price revisions, with select models becoming 3-31 per cent more expensive in July, as per the All India Mobile Retailers Association. The company has increased chipmaking prices in a move aimed at preventing customers from shifting to rival foundries.

According to Faisal Ka-

woosa, Chief Analyst and Founder of Techarc, the move will give Samsung an upper hand in a worsening situation. “Samsung will end up booking the hikes as it has its own memory arm. It will not have price increase for itself. Moreover, Samsung has the highest resale value compared to any brand. It is likely to become the leader again,” said Kawoosa.

Another industry source told *businessline* that the move is a result of pricing pressure. As chipset prices rise, brands are increasingly relying on higher average selling prices, which are expected to increase by around 15 per cent. These trends are likely to continue until the AI-driven demand cycle subsides or India commissions its upcoming semiconductor fabrication units, anticipated to become operational by mid-2027.

“Rising device prices are

Price hike

Brand	Total hike % (since Nov 2025)	July 2026
Vivo	4 to 91	4 to 27
Oppo	3 to 53	4 to 17
Realme	3 to 81	2 to 11
Xiaomi	2 to 50	4 to 9
Samsung	2 to 50	3 to 31
Oneplus	5 to 25	5 to 9
Nothing	24 to 33	4 to 7
Poco	7 to 38	5 to 9
Google	12	12

Source: All India Mobile Retailers Association

making consumers increasingly value-conscious and more dependent on promotional offers. This trend has become more visible over the past few months, with sales seeing temporary spikes during major promotional events, followed by a sharp normalisation once these offers end,” said Prachir Singh, Senior Analyst, Counter-

point Research.

The impact of higher prices is extending beyond short-term sales trends and is increasingly influencing consumer upgrade cycles.

SALES PERFORMANCE

Despite the subdued market performance, Apple, which maintained prices, recorded the strongest sales growth between April and July, with volumes rising 15 per cent y-o-y. Robust demand for the iPhone 17 series, combined with affordability-focused offers, contributed to this.

Oppo posted 4 per cent annual growth, supported by healthy demand for its budget-oriented A and K series devices.

Samsung also recorded 4 per cent y-o-y growth, benefiting from its enhanced focus on the mainline retail channel and aggressive promotional offers across its A and S series portfolios.

With ‘Japan City’, UP woos investments in chips, data centres, advanced manufacturing

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

Uttar Pradesh is developing a dedicated ‘Japan City’ to anchor its expanding partnership with Japan and create a new industrial ecosystem spanning semiconductors, data centres, electronics and advanced manufacturing, Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath said on Wednesday.

Speaking at the UP-Japan Investment Meet 2026, Adityanath said the partnership was no longer confined to automobiles but was expanding into advanced manufacturing and emerging technology sectors. “We are pushing investments in semiconductors, data centres and electronics manufacturing units in the State,” he said.

Adityanath said UP had 36 sectoral policies, including



EXPANDING PARTNERSHIP. Union Ministers Ashwini Vaishnaw (second from left) and Shivraj Singh Chouhan (second from right) with Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath (third from left) during the UP-Japan Investment Meet 2026 **PTI**

those covering IT/ITeS, green hydrogen, solar power, food processing and defence infrastructure, while the State had more than 75,000 acres of dedicated industrial land bank, and 27 manufacturing and logistics clusters are being developed along the expressway network.

Priority is being given to textiles and apparel, automobiles and electric mobility, chemicals and global capability centres (GCCs), with five dedicated sectoral desks established to facilitate in-

vestments. The Japan City initiative is being accompanied by a fresh wave of Japanese manufacturing investments.

Adityanath, with Governor of Nagasaki Ken Hirata and Governor of Yamanashi Kotaro Nagasaki, virtually attended the ground-breaking ceremonies for projects by Escorts Kubota and Minda Corporation.

GREENFIELD FACILITY Escorts Kubota is investing around ₹2,025 crore in a

greenfield facility in Sector-10 of the Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority (YEIDA).

Shingo Hanada, President and CEO of Kubota Corporation, said India was “no longer only a market for Kubota” but was “becoming a manufacturing and engineering hub for Kubota globally”. He said India was one of the world’s largest and fastest growing tractor markets and played a significant role in Kubota’s growth strategy for 2030.

Minda Corporation has proposed investments of ₹1,166 crore in two projects in Sector 10 and Sector 24 of YEIDA. “Between the new YEIDA units and our upcoming manufacturing facilities, we are creating meaningful employment and pushing our production capacity,” said Aakash Minda, Executive Director, Minda Corporation.

QUICKLY.

Peeko raises ₹67.4 crore in Series A funding



Bengaluru: Peeko, a babycare platform for new-age parents, has raised ₹67.4 crore in its Series A funding round led by Chiratae Ventures, with participation from existing investor Stellaris Venture Partners and prominent angel investors. The new capital will be used for business expansion, technology development and team hiring, as the company prepares to enter new cities. **OUR BUREAU**

Jassper Shipping to invest \$50 m to expand cargo ops

Hyderabad: Jassper Shipping, a provider of project logistics, break-bulk, bulk cargo and industrial supply-chain solutions, is planning to invest \$50 million over the next three years. The capital, to be infused in a phased manner, is intended to strengthen its capabilities across project logistics, heavy-lift transportation, vessel chartering, and multimodal cargo solutions. The first phase of the investment programme will see \$10 million deployed to expand the company's B2B project logistics business. **OUR BUREAU**

Q-comm discounts cool as competition heats up

\$58 B MARKET. The next phase will be about who can produce better economics: Experts

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

The discount war in India's quick-commerce sector may be cooling. Discounts across major platforms have fallen to 19-20 per cent over the past three to four months from the peak it hit earlier this year.

Amazon Now was among the most aggressive players during the price war in early 2026, said experts, pointing to the company nearly doubling discounts to 57 per cent in the two months to January. This even as Flipkart Minutes and incumbent platforms stepped up discounts by 200-300 basis points across categories.

But the competitive bar seems to be rising, too. Larger e-commerce firms are building 400-600 dark stores and could scale to 1,200-1,500 over the next 12-18 months, according to UBS.

MORE ROOM
Quick commerce has expanded to more than 100 towns, prompting UBS to raise its total addressable market estimates to \$59 billion by FY30 from \$34 billion earlier.

It expects quick commerce to capture roughly



COOLING PRICE WARS. Discounts across major platforms have fallen to 19-20 per cent over the past three to four months

half of incremental online retail growth.

Experts said dark stores are increasingly fulfilling purchases of electronics, personal care, apparel, and other non-grocery products traditionally sold through conventional e-commerce.

The improving economics are giving established players more room to respond, too. Blinkit leads the market ahead of Instamart and Zepto. The companies have considerable firepower to fund expansion and perhaps withstand another bout of aggressive spending, too, said experts, pointing to their huge cash reserves (nearly ₹18,000 crore each for Eternal and Swiggy, and ₹7,000 crore with Zepto).

Blinkit's Q1 performance showed rapid net order value

growth alongside a positive adjusted EBITDA margin, according to UBS. Instamart reached a contribution-margin break-even in May and Zepto cut discounts and removed more than four million unprofitable users as it pushed towards contribution-margin break-even, experts said. The company increased discounts again in early July as it pivoted back towards growth.

A DIFFERENT WAR
Better unit economics, however, don't necessarily translate into the margins once expected from the business.

UBS has cut its steady-state margin expectations by 250-300 basis points as non-metro expansion, lower-margin non-grocery categories, and sustained multi-

● **FIREPOWER**

Eternal and Swiggy, experts say, have reserves of about ₹18,000 crore each, while Zepto has nearly ₹7,000 crore

player competition alter industry economics. Platforms are increasingly turning to advertising monetisation, brand-funded promotions, and platform and delivery fees.

FOOD DELIVERY

A similar push is playing out in food delivery, where more than 70 per cent of users transact less than once a month. Zomato and Swiggy Food Delivery are offering lower-priced baskets, reduced restaurant commissions, simplified fees, tighter delivery radii, and greater batching. Early evidence cited by UBS from one initiative showed two-thirds of customers were either new or previously dormant.

The next phase, experts said, will be less about who can open the most dark stores or offer the deepest discounts and more about who can extract the best economics from them.

Swiggy's inventory-led shift could give Instamart an edge

Jyoti Banthia
Bengaluru

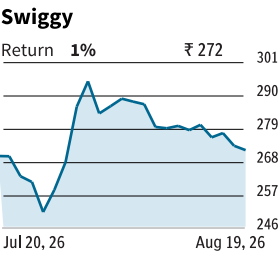
Swiggy's move to qualify as an Indian owned and controlled company (IOCC) could mark an important shift in the way it operates Instamart.

Swiggy's shareholders, on August 18, approved a 49.5 per cent cap on aggregate foreign ownership, along with changes to its governance structure, clearing a key hurdle in its effort to qualify as an IOCC. The inventory-led model would allow Instamart to buy and

hold products directly, subject to applicable regulations and business requirements.

WHAT IT MEANS
The immediate implication is greater control over procurement. Instead of relying entirely on third-party sellers and intermediaries, Instamart could increasingly source products directly from brands and manufacturers. This could help the company negotiate better procurement terms and retain a larger portion of the margin generated on every order.

For a business operating



on thin margins, even a small improvement can become meaningful at scale. "An inventory-led model, unlocked once Swiggy qualifies as an IOCC, could add ₹4-5 per order on top," Equirus Securities said in a recent report.

The benefit, Equirus estimates, could be worth around 80 basis points of contribution margin. But inventory ownership is an incremental lever rather than the primary reason behind Instamart's recent improvement in profitability, it added. Instamart's contribution loss narrowed from 7.4 per cent of net order value in Q4 FY25 to 0.3 per cent in Q1 FY27.

OTHER RISKS
Owning inventory also means greater responsibility for working capital, inventory management, and unsold

or slow-moving products. The economics will therefore depend on how efficiently Instamart can turn inventory while maintaining availability across its dark stores.

Eternal had said around 90 per cent of Blinkit's net order value was already on its own inventory. Instamart reached contribution break-even in May, but Equirus says growth remains the bigger test, with NOV rising only 3 per cent sequentially in the June quarter. The company has restarted store additions, with about 75 stores expected to be added in Q2.

'Crackdown on food companies led to corrective action, accountability'

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

After pulling up various companies for misleading labelling and other violations, the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI), in the past few days, has been putting the spotlight on corrective action taken by food companies.

On Wednesday, the FSSAI said in a social media post that various companies had withdrawn "100 per cent" claims from their labels, packaging, promotional and ad materials after it initiated action against them.

● **TICK-TOCK**

FSSAI is said to have given companies dealing with alcobev products a 90-day window to comply with its directions on artificial flavours

"Regulatory oversight continues to drive accountability across the food industry..." it said in an Instagram post. These players include Bonn Biscuits, Amway India, MasterChow Foods, Apis India and Kerala-based Juza Foods.

On Tuesday, too, FSSAI said "major food business operators" had taken prompt corrective actions. While it noted that Lotte India had rectified claims on the labels, Eat Better Ventures had removed comparative and vegan claims.

NOTICE TO DABUR
Incidentally, in its social media post on Tuesday, FSSAI said it had sent a notice to Dabur India on the selling of Ayurvedic proprietary oil as edible oil. The company has taken action to list it under the appropriate category on e-commerce platforms and its website, FSSAI said.

New product lines to help achieve quarterly break-even in CPG vertical: EID Parry CEO

Our Bureau
Chennai

Murugappa Group's EID Parry aims to achieve quarterly break-even in its Consumer Products Group (CPG) segment in the next four to five quarters, driven by new product lines, distribution expansion and margin improvement.

This is despite the segment recoding a sharp fall in revenue in Q1, a trend that Muthiah Murugappan, Whole-Time Director and CEO, EID Parry, said was intentional and not a sign of

weak demand. The absolute margin pool has grown given the company's focus on a more margin-accretive product mix, he told analysts in an earnings call.

EID Parry's turnover nearly halved to about ₹94 crore in CPG in Q1 from the year-ago period.

UNDER EXPLORATION

When asked if newer product categories would come from organic launches or acquisitions, Murugappan said both paths remain under exploration. A new jagery plant is coming online in Karnataka within six



Muthiah Murugappan, CEO, EID Parry **BIJOY GHOSH**

months and is set to "more than double" the capacity, he added, bringing in a turnover of nearly ₹100 crore.

On a short-term year roadmap for EID Parry, Murugappan said, "There is a climate of restructure" and the

aspiration is to have a consistent EBITDA generation from core business. "We will work on cost and efficiency to fix and restructure this," he said.

As for the ethanol mix, the CEO said that sugar diversion to ethanol is about 2.9 million tonnes supporting the government's E20 programme. "We expect level to remain at 20 per cent for the foreseeable future," he said.

The company crushed 1.47 lakh tonnes of cane in Tamil Nadu during the quarter, down from 2.12 lakh tonnes a year ago.

Nikhil Kamath, Sreeram Vanga invest ₹250 cr in CtrlS

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Hyperscale datacentre operator CtrlS has raised ₹250 crore from Zerodha co-founder Nikhil Kamath and entrepreneur Sreeram Reddy Vanga, with the former investing 80 per cent of the corpus. The capital will support CtrlS' infrastructure expansion and capacity build-out to meet growing enterprise and hyperscaler demand in India, as AI workload accelerates.

"Over the years, we have built CtrlS with a long-term vision of where India's digital economy is headed and the digital infrastructure it will require," said Sridhar Pinnareddy, Founder and CEO. The partnership, he said, gives the company "the

ability to think bigger, move faster, and continue building data centre platforms".

The nearly two-decade-old firm operates 19 data centres in India with over 370 MW of capacity and 4.4 GW of projects at various stages of execution.

'INFLECTION POINT'

"India is at an inflection point where the underlying infrastructure either keeps pace or becomes the bottleneck. CtrlS has spent years building the kind of depth that does not get assembled overnight," said Kamath.

"India's AI and cloud ambitions will require world-class digital infrastructure at scale. I am excited to be part of CtrlS' next phase of growth and India's broader digital infrastructure opportunity," Vanga added.

Mahindra sees electric 3-wheelers scaling faster even as LCVs crawl

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

India's commercial EV transition is likely to move at two speeds.

Electric light commercial vehicles (LCVs) could see slower adoption because the charging infrastructure is not deep enough yet to give operators the route flexibility they need.

Meanwhile, electrification in L5 three-wheelers has already reached 40.2 per cent and is set to scale faster, according to Mahindra & Mahindra.

The company, which held 39.5 per cent share of the electric three-wheeler (e-3W) market in Q1 FY27, said its volumes grew 85 per cent year-on-year. Its broader last mile mobility volumes rose to 42,276 units from 25,111 a year earlier,



FINGERS CROSSED. The company hopes that the adoption curve could improve once users see the EV economics work and their concerns around charging and reliability recede **BLOOMBERG**

with electric volumes nearly doubling to 35,541. "We're at 40 per cent penetration. That means many markets which have pivoted earlier are at 70-80 per cent," Rajesh Jejurikar, Executive Director and CEO (Auto and Farm Sector), told *businessline*. Once commercial users are

convinced of the EV economics and their concerns around charging and reliability recede, "the adoption curve would be very fast," he added.

LCVs' PROBLEM

The equation changes for electric LCVs. Unlike three-

Lower returns hurt debt fund inflows in April-July 2026

Sourashis Banerjee
Chennai

Mutual-fund flows into income or debt-oriented schemes fell sharply in the four months to July 2026, while growth-oriented equity schemes managed a modest increase. Net inflows into debt-oriented schemes declined 28 per cent to ₹2.20-lakh crore from ₹3.06-lakh crore in the corresponding period last year.

DATA FOCUS.

Hybrid schemes also saw their inflows fall nearly 30 per cent y-o-y to ₹55,509 crore.

As a result, total net inflows into mutual-fund schemes fell 17.3 per cent y-o-y to ₹4.41-lakh crore in the first four months of FY27.

MOMENTUM LOST

The slowdown in debt-oriented schemes was concentrated in several major categories. Money market funds, which had attracted ₹96,788 crore in net inflows in April-July 2025, received only ₹6,536 crore in the corresponding period this year.

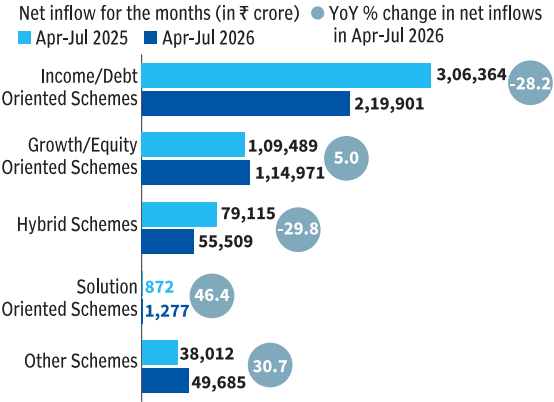
Low-duration funds swung from a ₹25,407 crore inflow to a ₹17,803 crore outflow, while corporate bond funds moved from a ₹23,988 crore inflow to a ₹9,155 crore outflow during the period. Short-duration funds, similarly, shifted from an ₹18,659 crore inflow to a ₹5,017 crore outflow.

"Debt or income schemes benefitted substantially from investors parking money in money-market, liquid, and short-duration products, particularly when yields were attractive," said Venkatakrishnan Srinivasan, Founder and Managing Partner of Rockfort Pincap LLP. "As the interest-rate cycle has moved lower, the incremental return available from many traditional debt funds has become less compelling."

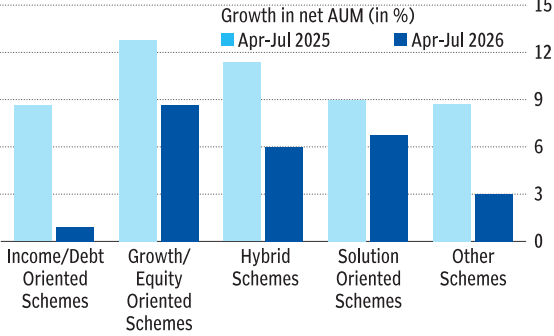
Debt-oriented mutual funds have been under pressure since the Finance Act, 2023, removed long term capital gains and indexation benefit, thereby reducing the tax attractiveness for investors, particularly those in

Losing appeal

Debt funds face outflows



Growth in net AUM between April and July moderated in 2026 across all scheme types



Net outflows from corporate bond funds and low duration funds led the slowdown

Scheme	Net inflow during Apr-Jul 2025 (in ₹ crore)	Net inflow during Apr-Jul 2026 (in ₹ crore)
Low Duration Fund	25,407	-17,803
Money Market Fund	96,788	6,536
Short Duration Fund	18,659	-5,017
Medium Duration Fund	50	-904
Medium to Long Duration Fund	-143	-1,208
Long Duration Fund	-314	-2,962
Dynamic Bond Fund	663	-2,901
Corporate Bond Fund	23,988	-9,155
Credit Risk Fund	-989	1,760
Banking and PSU Fund	697	-2,948
Gilt Fund	-102	-4,646
ELSS	-83	-48

Source: AMFI

the higher tax brackets. "There has been a migration to equity schemes due to better returns and tax benefits," said Madan Sabnavis, Chief Economist at Bank of Baroda.

NET AUM GROWTH

Nishchay Nath of fixed-income investment platform BondScanner, said: "A large part of the money in debt-fund flows is tactical and institutional in nature. July's sharp reversal in debt flows

itself shows that this is not a structural shift from fixed income," he said.

The moderation was also visible in net AUM growth. Growth in debt-oriented schemes slowed to 0.9 per cent in the first four months of FY27 from 8.6 per cent in the year-ago period.

Equity-oriented schemes also slowed to 8.7 per cent from 12.8 per cent growth, while hybrid schemes fell to 6 per cent from 11.4 per cent during the period.

SEBI restrains Dhenu allottees over ₹1,000 cr loan transactions

Press Trust Of India
New Delhi

Markets regulator SEBI has barred six preferential allottees of Dhenu Buildcon Infra from disposing of company shares after finding *prima facie* evidence of round-tripping of funds, involving purported loans of ₹1,000 crore.

In an interim order passed on Wednesday, SEBI said the company purportedly received ₹1,000 crore from seven entities through 46 transactions over eight days in 2024. But the examination of bank accounts showed that the amount was not backed by corresponding fresh inflows from independent external sources.

PREFERENTIAL SHARES
Instead, an initial pool of ₹25 crore was repeatedly circulated through multiple entities and returned to Dhenu Buildcon Infra through different routes, creating the appearance of aggregate receipts of ₹1,000 crore, the regulator said.

SEBI said ₹840 crore of the purported loans were subsequently converted into equity through a preferential allotment of over 591 crore equity shares.

businessline.

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QUICKLY.

FM leads team to Singapore for ministerial roundtable



New Delhi: Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Wednesday embarked on an official visit to Singapore with a ministerial delegation to participate in the 4th India-Singapore Ministerial Roundtable (ISMR). Sitharaman is leading a delegation comprising S Jaishankar, Minister of External Affairs; Piyush Goyal, Minister for Commerce & Industry; and Jitin Prasada, Minister of State for Electronics & IT and Commerce & Industry. The roundtable is scheduled for August 19-20, the Finance Ministry said in a post on X. [PH](#)

Non-print biz to grow 12% for major newspapers

Mumbai: Revenue from non-print businesses, including digital platforms, out-of-home advertising and event management, is estimated to grow by up to 12 per cent between FY25-FY27 for major newspapers versus an expansion of up to 3 per cent in core print revenues amid declining readership, a Cricil Ratings report said on Wednesday. [PH](#)

Maritime disruptions, drone attacks push up risk premium on crude oil

FRAGILE FLOWS. Discounts dry up as oil supply concerns persist; impact seen on imports, CAD and OMC profits

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Repeated maritime disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz (SoH) and Bab el-Mandeb (BeM), coupled with persistent drone attacks on Russian oil and gas infrastructure, is not only pushing up the risk premium on crude oil prices, but also weakening discounts that hit zero in some cases.

Sources said that constant geopolitical disruptions in the Middle East Gulf (MEG) region impacted crude oil supply, particularly from Saudi Arabia. Besides, Ukraine drone attacks on Russian refineries and crude export terminals have also led to stretched supplies of Ural grade.

“These issues coupled with lack of clarity on peace talks between Iran and the US are impacting supply and prices. Russian discounts have hit rock bottom, even zero in some cases. Also, the uncertainty around shipments and safety of passage is forcing traders to charge risk premiums,” explained one of the sources.

An official with a domestic



IN TROUBLED WATERS. Regional exports, including routes bypassing the SoH, fell by 2.1 mb/d to 15 mb/d after the key passageway was closed again in early July [REUTERS](#)

refiner noted that the market is not fearing an immediate collapse in crude oil supplies. However, no one is expecting a swift return to normalcy either. Adding to this is the constant threat of maritime disruptions, which is putting upward pressure on prices.

SAUDI ARABIAN SUPPLIES The spectre of widening risk premiums with low-to-almost-zero discounts will not only have a bearing on India’s crude oil import bill, but also adversely impact its current account deficit (CAD) and profit of the oil marketing companies

(OMCs). The International Energy Agency (IEA), in its August 2026 oil market report, noted that global crude oil supply rose by 2.4 million barrels per day (mb/d) to 101.5 mb/d in July, but remained 6.3 mb/d below year-ago levels, with 8.3 mb/d of Gulf output still shut in.

“Renewed hostilities and maritime disruptions in July and early August undermined the recovery efforts, reducing projected Q3 2026 oil supply by 1.7 mb/d compared with last month’s Report. Global oil supply is now projected to decline by 4.3 mb/d on average in 2026 and

rebound by 8.3 mb/d next year to 110.3 mb/d.

After an increase of 3.7 mb/d in June, Gulf oil production rose by a further 2.5 mb/d in July to 23.9 mb/d, still 8.3 mb/d below pre-war levels.

Regional exports, including routes bypassing the SoH, fell by a sharp 2.1 mb/d to 15 mb/d after the key passageway was effectively closed again in early July and oil infrastructure and tankers came under attack. Loadings peaked at 20 mb/d at the start of July but dropped to around 12 mb/d later in the month, it added.

DRONE ATTACKS

According to Wood Mackenzie’s H2 2026 commodity trading guide, around 2.7 mb/d of Russian refining capacity was offline for maintenance as of July 2026, with most of it unplanned following intensified Ukrainian drone strikes forcing Russia to import gasoline from India via its northern terminals while introducing an export ban on diesel.

Daria Melnik, Vice-President of Oil & Gas Research at Rystad Energy, in an August 17 commentary explained

that the increasing frequency and effectiveness of drone attacks on Russian oil and gas infrastructure is no longer affecting only refineries. It’s constraining the country’s upstream sector as well.

He pointed out that Russian refinery runs in June and July were among the lowest recorded in the past two decades, while throughput is forecast to average around 4 mb/d between July and December, almost 30 per cent below the 2016-2023 seasonal average of roughly 5.7 mb/d. Rystad Energy expects refinery activity to recover gradually as the intensity of drone attacks eases.

“Even so, Russia is still likely to process around 1.4 mb/d less crude in the second half of the year than historical seasonal patterns would suggest. Every barrel not processed by a refinery must either be exported, placed into storage or removed from production. While Russia was able to absorb that imbalance in June, July demonstrated that its export system cannot consistently handle the additional volumes,” Melnik explained.

Rajnath, Japan Minister to discuss co-production of naval antenna system

Our Bureau
New Delhi



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh will hold bilateral meeting with Japanese counterpart Shinjiro Koizumi on Thursday, with the two sides expected to discuss co-production of the UNICORN (Unified Complex Radio Antenna) mast announced earlier for future Indian Navy warships.

In July 2026, both the countries formally announced the co-development the cutting-edge naval antenna system UNICORN for Indian Navy platforms, which is commonly known as “Nora-50”.

As per a memorandum of implementation (MoI) signed on November 15, 2024, Japan will provide the design and engineering support, while India will handle integration, adaptation and co-production through Bharat Electronics Ltd (BEL).

RADAR MASTS

The UNICORN system is regarded as one of the most advanced weapon-grade composite radar masts in the world.

It is currently deployed aboard Mogami-class frigates of the Japan Maritime

Self-Defence Force. According to a statement issued by the Ministry of Defence on Wednesday, the two Ministers will exchange views on deeper maritime security co-operation and closer defence equipment and technology collaboration under the ‘Make-in-India’ framework, following Japan’s revision of the Three Principles on Transfer of Defence Equipment and Technology, indicating at the forward movement over UNICORN joint production.

Overall, the meeting is expected to further strengthen bilateral defence relations, enhance strategic trust and co-operation, promote stability and security in the Indo-Pacific region and identify new areas of collaboration.

Cabinet gives green signal to five rail and road projects worth ₹13,041 crore

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Union Cabinet on Wednesday approved five projects, including four for the Railways and one of highways, together worth ₹13,041 crore, with Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw emphasising that the government’s focus on expanding the rail network is backed by transport economics.

Comparatively, the cost of transportation through rail works out to 46.67 per cent cheaper than road transportation though shipping freight is the cheapest among three modes of transportation — through land, air and water.

While transportation through rail costs ₹1.6 per tonne-km, the cost goes up to ₹3 per tonne-km when goods are transported by road, Vaishnaw told reporters at a briefing to announce Cabinet decisions. It is cheapest to transport goods by ship, at just 55 paise per tonne-km, while air freight is the costliest, ranging from ₹9 to ₹35-40 per tonne-km, the Minister said.

Another point the Minister shared was that between road and rail, rail freight could be up to 90 per cent less carbon-intensive than road freight. This would hold true if the comparison is between train sets and road carriers running on diesel fuel, he emphasised, adding that rail cargo had seen 10 per cent growth. The Railways, being an



CONNECTIVITY BOOST. Union Minister for Information and Broadcasting Ashwini Vaishnaw at the Cabinet briefing in New Delhi on Wednesday [SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA](#)

environment friendly and energy efficient mode of transportation, will help both in achieving climate goals and minimising logistics cost of the country, reduce oil import (~13 crore litres) and lower CO₂ emissions (~65 crore kg) which is equivalent to the plantation of 2.6 crore trees, the Minister stated.

HOWRAH-CHENNAI LINE

The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs, chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, approved four projects of the Ministry of Railways with total cost of ₹9,450 crore approximately, aimed at quadrupling sections of the Howrah-Chennai main railway line to increase passenger and freight capacity on the key East Coast corridor.

These projects include: Kharagpur-Bhadrak (Ranital) fourth railway line, spread across 173 km between West Bengal and Odisha which will involve a cost of ₹3,352 crore. Another stretch is the Bhadrak-Haridaspur fourth line, covering 75 km in Odisha and involving an expenditure of ₹1,583 crore.

Likewise, the Gummidipundi-Gudur third and fourth line, covering 90 km between Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu, will involve a cost of ₹2,229 crore.

The Cuttack-Paradeep (Badabandha) phase is part of the third and fourth line that is stretched across 72 km in Odisha at a cost of ₹2,286 crore.

The proposed projects are essential routes for transportation of commodities such as coal,

iron ore, cement, iron and steel, container, automobiles and foodgrains, the Minister stated. The capacity augmentation works will result in additional freight traffic of magnitude 76 million tonnes per annum.

Planned on the PM-Gati Shakti National Master Plan, the projects will focus on enhancing multi-modal connectivity and logistic efficiency through integrated planning and stakeholder consultations.

The projects will provide seamless connectivity for movement of people, goods and services as they cover eight districts across West Bengal, Odisha, Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh, and will increase the existing network of the Indian Railways by 410 km. The proposed projects will enhance connectivity to 6,448 villages.

The Cabinet also gave nod to the upgradation of the Muzaffarpur-Sitamari-Sonbarsa Section of NH-22 to four-lane standards in Bihar. The project, covering 82.578 km, will be developed on hybrid annuity mode at a capital cost of ₹3,590.73 crore.

It acts as a key feeder corridor connecting the India-Nepal border at Sonbarsa with economic centres like Muzaffarpur at NH-27 (East-West Corridor). The project will significantly reduce congestion in densely populated areas of Muzaffarpur, Mukhsudpur, Runni Saidpur, Thumma, Dumra, Bhutahi and Sonbarsa.

DoT starts process to disband Digital Communication Commission

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The Department of Telecom has begun the process of disbanding the Digital Communication Commission, formerly known as the Telecom Commission, the apex inter-ministerial body formed to make decisions on policy matters and subjects with significant financial implications.

The body comprises the Telecom Secretary as its Chairman, four full-time members, who are ex-officio Secretaries to the Government of India in the Department of Telecommunications and four part-time members who are the secretaries to the Government of India in the concerned Departments.

“The process for seeking Cabinet nod to dissolve the Digital Communication Commission has started,” an official source told PTI.

Among the ex-officio secretaries, the post of member (technology) and member (services) are lying vacant, and the government has no plans to fill them.

Member (Finance) Manish Sinha will superannuate in February 2027, the source said.

India steps up CBAM preparedness as EU carbon payments begin in 2027

Our Bureau
New Delhi

With the EU’s carbon tax regime under the Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) coming into force from January 2026 and financial payments beginning in 2027, the Commerce Department is reaching out to exporters and industry stakeholders to step up preparedness for the new regime, focusing on emissions data, reporting, accreditation and verification requirements.

The Department of Commerce, in collaboration with the National Accreditation Board for Certification Bodies and the Engineering Export Promotion Council, organised an awareness session at Vanija Bhawan, New Delhi, with around 100 exporters and industry stakeholders participating,



stepping up efforts to prepare Indian exporters for the new regime and its financial impact from 2027.

The EU’s CBAM currently covers iron & steel products, aluminium, fertilizers, cement, electricity and hydro-gen sectors. “Practical case studies relating to the iron and steel and aluminium sectors were discussed to provide exporters with a better understanding of the application of requirements in practice,” according to a government statement.

CARBON COSTS

For Indian exporters, the mechanism could increase the effective cost of carbon-

intensive exports to the EU and affect competitiveness, particularly where producers cannot provide verified actual emissions data.

EEPC India Chairman Pankaj Chadha highlighted the importance of awareness and preparedness across the export value chain, including the availability of appropriate emissions-related data from suppliers and other stakeholders.

The outreach comes as Indian exporters face the challenge of establishing reliable emissions data and verification systems across their supply chains to meet EU requirements. Under the definitive regime, which began on January 1, 2026, EU importers are required to report embedded emissions annually and surrender CBAM certificates. The first annual declaration and surrender of certificates will be due by September 30, 2027.

STOVE KRAFT LIMITED

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CIN No: L29301KA1999PLC025387



NOTICE

This is in continuation to our earlier communication dated August 07, 2026, vide which we had informed that 27th Annual General Meeting ('AGM') of the Company will be held on Friday, September 11, 2026 at 11.00 A.M. through Video Conference ('VC') / Other Audio Visual Means ('OAVM') without physical presence of the members at a common venue, in compliance with the provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 (the 'Act') read with circulars issued by Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA circulars") and SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ('Listing Regulations'), to transact the business as set out in the Notice of 27th AGM.

In compliance with the said MCA circulars and Listing Regulations, the Company has sent the Notice of 27th AGM and Annual Report for FY2025-26 through electronic mode to all the members whose email IDs are registered with the depository participant(s) / KFin Technologies Limited, RTA of the Company (hereinafter referred to as 'KFin'). The Annual Report for 2025-26 is also available on the website of the Company at <https://www.stovekraft.com/investors/>, website of the stock exchanges, i.e., BSE Limited at www.bseindia.com and National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.nseindia.com and on the website of KFin at <https://evoting.kfintech.com>.

Pursuant to provisions of Section 108 of the Act and Rule 20 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014, Regulation 44 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, members holding shares as on the cut-off date, i.e., September 04, 2026 may cast their vote electronically on the business as set out in the Notice of 27th AGM through e-voting platform. The detailed procedure/instructions for e-voting are contained in the Notice of 27th AGM.

In this regard, the members are hereby further notified that Remote e-voting will commence from September 08, 2026 (9.00 a.m.) and shall end on September 10, 2026 (5.00 p.m.). Remote e-voting will not be allowed beyond 5.00 p.m. on September 10, 2026. Cut-off date for the purpose of e-voting will be September 04, 2026. Persons who have acquired shares and have become members of the Company after the dispatch of Notice and who are eligible shareholders as on the cut-off date, i.e., September 04, 2026 may obtain the user ID and password from KFin by sending request to email id einward.ris@kfintech.com. Members present at the meeting through VC/OAVM and who had not cast their votes on the resolutions through remote e-voting, shall be eligible to vote through e-voting system during the AGM. The instructions for attending the AGM through VC/OAVM are provided in the Notice of 27th AGM. Members who have cast their votes by remote e-voting prior to the AGM may also attend/participate in the AGM through VC/OAVM facility, but shall not be allowed to cast their votes again at the AGM. A person whose name is recorded in the register of members or in the register of beneficial owners maintained by the depositories as on the cut-off date shall only be entitled to avail of the facility of remote e-voting as well as e-voting during the AGM.

In case of queries/grievances by Individual Shareholders holding securities in demat mode who need assistance or for any technical issues related to e-voting through Depository, i.e., NSDL and CDSL, may get in touch with respective depository as per contact details given below:

Members facing any technical issue – NSDL	Members facing any technical issue – CDSL
May contact by sending a request at evoting@nsdl.co.in or call on toll free no.: 1800 1020 990 and 1800 22 44 30	Please contact CDSL helpdesk by sending a request at helpdesk.evoting@cdslindia.com or contact at 022-62343625, 022-62343626, 022-62343259

In case of any queries/grievances related to e-voting, other than individual shareholder holding securities in demat mode, may contact following persons Mr. Shyam Kumar, Senior Manager - Corporate Registry KFin Technologies Limited, Selenium Tower B, Plot 31-32, Gachibowli Financial District, Nanakramguda, Hyderabad – 500 032.

Email ID: einward.ris@kfintech.com, Toll free no.: 1800-309-4001.

Members who have not registered their email addresses and mobile numbers, are requested to temporarily get themselves registered with KFin, by visiting the link <https://ris.kfintech.com/client/services/mobile/mobilereg/mobileemailreg.aspx> to receive copies of the Annual Report for FY2025-26 along with the Notice of 27th AGM.

Further the Company has fixed, Friday, September 04, 2026, as the “Record Date” for the purpose of determining the members eligible to receive Dividend for FY2025-26 and attend AGM. The Dividend on Equity Shares, if declared, at the AGM will be paid to the members within 30 days from the date of AGM.

By order of the Board
For Stove Kraft Limited

Shrinivas P Harapanahalli
(Company Secretary & Compliance Officer)
Membership no: A26590

Place: Bangalore
Date: August 20, 2026

Unhealthy situation

Private healthcare needs better regulation

The 176th Parliamentary panel report on health and hospitals comprehensively points out the ways in which patients suffer a bad deal. They are faced with twin crises of access and affordability, because public health facilities are inadequate in relation to the demand for them, while private care at the secondary and tertiary levels is concentrated in the southern States and large cities and is 10 times as expensive.



The private sector caters to over 60 per cent of inpatient and 70 per cent of outpatient care, and its service quality and price are largely unregulated in practice. The report flags these rather well-known facts, but the challenge lies in ensuring that solutions are implemented. There are three broad domains to be looked into. These pertain to regulating hospitals in terms of providing good healthcare at reasonable prices; ensuring that the insurance system works for most; and raising budgetary outlays on health to ensure access and affordability. On the first, the House panel rightly says that hospitals should display their ‘schedule of charges’ and create a national body to implement a cap on procedures and diagnostics. A standardised treatment protocol too would empower patients. The suggestion that hospitals should set aside 20 per cent of their beds for free treatment for the tax cuts and subsidies they get has been established even in court, but has simply not been implemented. Similarly, a national health regulator has not been effective.

Amidst this regulatory tardiness, corporate hospitals have prospered. The top three corporate hospitals have seen their EBITDA margins grow from 9.3 per cent in FY19 to 19.4 per cent in FY26. Accreditation for hospitals, that ensures minimum standards, is at present voluntary. The report calls for a mandatory framework making the accreditation body NABH’s system transparent and friendly even to the small health establishments. The Clinical Establishments Act needs to be evenly implemented. A report by this newspaper cites a few reputed hospitals having a cost accounting department. Meanwhile, the panel report rightly notes the importance of pooling medicine procurement.

On insurance, the panel report observes that while insurance coverage is 46 per cent, out-of-pocket expenditure per episode is over ₹34,000 on average, a data point that at once indicates that insurance does not cover costs adequately, and that the latter are extremely high. However, the report could have gone further than merely urge the insurance regulator to look into these issues, and suggest modifications in Ayushman Bharat, a successful measure that however needs to hook in private players by raising its reimbursement rates. Insurance claim denials are a huge concern. Meanwhile, the report’s suggestion to raise public health spending to 5 per cent of GDP (less than 2 per cent now) is unexceptionable, as public health facilities alone can guarantee both quality and universal coverage.

OTHER VOICES.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

High anxiety in the bond market

Apparently “rout” is the new word for interest rates returning to a historical norm. That’s one impression from the freakout now attending a repricing in global bond markets that’s resetting the global financial system to its pre-2008 level. Note the dates here. The 30-year US Treasury yield on Tuesday touched 5.339 per cent, its highest since 2007. The 10-year at about 4.7 per cent is near its highest level since early 2025. The benchmark French 10-year, at about 4.1 per cent, is its highest since 2008. The 10-year German bund, at about 3.26 per cent, has returned to its level of 2011. None of these moves upward have been sudden, despite the hubbub in market commentary this week. (NEW YORK, AUGUST 18)

CHINADAILY

Mexico should handle trade issues prudently

The Mexican government is reportedly exploring the possibility of further expanding the trade restrictions and raising tariffs on certain imported goods, while continuing case-by-case investigations into alleged “dumping” by China and other countries. In January, Mexico imposed tariffs of up to 50 per cent on approximately 1,500 products from nations with which it does not have a free trade agreement, a policy that has directly impacted China. Bilateral economic cooperation is based on international rules and market principles, with mutual benefit as its defining characteristic. Politicizing economic issues serves no one’s interests. Mexico should think twice before moving forward with the new trade restrictions. The move comes as Mexico is seeking to persuade the US to lower tariffs on its automotive and steel products. (BEIJING, AUGUST 19)

The case for tax-free annuities

BANKABLE. A retiree’s income, secured through an annuity, is less likely to require emergency state support in old age



TC SUSEEL KUMAR
R SUDHAKAR

There is a fundamental paradox at the heart of India’s public finance framework: the Union Government waives income tax for investors who lend it money for five years, yet levies lifetime slab-rate taxes on retirees who commit their savings for decades.

Consider Section 85 of the Income-Tax Act, 2025. A property seller with a large capital gain can secure a complete tax exemption up to ₹50 lakh by investing in five-year infrastructure bonds issued by entities such as REC, PFC, HUDCO and IRFC. The logic is clear: the sovereign forgoes short-term tax revenue to secure low-cost, directed capital for national infrastructure. A decade ago, tax-free infrastructure bonds under Section 10(15)(iv)(h) used the same model to channel retail savings into highways and railways.

Yet when an Indian retiree converts life savings into an annuity — providing regulated, long-duration capital that ultimately flows substantially into government securities — the sovereign offers no comparable income-tax relief. Instead, periodic annuity income is taxed at slab rates for life. India has left a valuable economic trade half-made.

The GST Council took an important first step on September 22, 2025, by exempting individual life insurance and annuity premiums from the GST. But the more consequential issue remains: income tax on the annuity payout.

WHERE THE CORPUS GOES

Under the National Pension System (NPS), contributions accumulate in market-linked funds with tax advantages. At retirement, up to 60 per cent of the corpus can be withdrawn tax-free, while the balance purchases an annuity from a PFRDA-empanelled provider, with the purchase itself exempt.

PFRDA regulations notified in December 2025 reduced mandatory annuitisation for non-government subscribers on normal exit from 40 per cent to 20 per cent, and removed it entirely for a corpus of ₹8 lakh or less. However, because the lump-sum exemption remains capped at 60 per cent, the additional 20 per cent now withdrawable is taxed at slab rates. Pension regulation has moved faster than the tax code.

Once the corpus reaches an insurer, IRDAI investment rules direct a substantial share into government



TOUGH TIMES. As India ages, household financial fragility in retirement will become a growing social-security challenge ISTOCK

securities and State Development Loans. Legally, the retiree owns an insurance contract; economically, the arrangement channels long-duration savings into sovereign debt through an insurer.

The contrast is striking. The tax-free bond investor receives an exemption for financing short-term state-directed borrowing. The annuity buyer provides vastly longer-duration capital and pays full slab-rate tax on the resulting income.

The case for annuities extends beyond tax parity. As India ages, household financial fragility in retirement will become a growing social-security challenge. Mutual-fund systematic withdrawal plans, equity portfolios and fixed deposits expose retirees to market volatility, reinvestment risk and the possibility of exhausting their capital.

Annuities uniquely transfer longevity risk to a regulated financial institution. Through mortality pooling, they guarantee income for as long as the annuitant lives.

In retirement-planning discussions, annuities are routinely absent since tax-conscious advisers have little incentive to recommend a product whose payouts are taxed at slab rates.

Outside the NPS, the position is worse. That corpus is already-taxed household savings, and Indian law has no exclusion ratio, splitting each payout

Annuity combines three public objectives: mobilising long-term capital, transferring longevity risk away from households and reducing potential future dependence on state-supported old-age welfare

into capital returned and interest earned. Part of every taxed payment is the buyer’s own capital, taxed twice.

THE PROPOSAL

The predictable objection from the Ministry of Finance and CBDT could be that NPS subscribers already enjoy substantial tax benefits and that exempting annuity payouts would create excessive tax shelter.

But this overlooks the annuity’s economic function. Its income is substantially generated by the insurer’s deployment of funds into long-duration debt, including government securities. Taxing the payout therefore taxes the return generated by capital that is simultaneously financing the sovereign.

More importantly, the annuity combines three public objectives: mobilising long-term capital, transferring longevity risk away from households and reducing potential future dependence on state-supported old-age welfare.

Parliament should therefore provide that annual annuity income up to ₹12 lakh be excluded from total income for regulated lifetime annuity products issued by IRDAI-registered insurers, with a flat 10 per cent final withholding tax on the excess.

To prevent arbitrage, the concession should apply only to lifetime annuities purchased at or after superannuation, including variants that return the purchase price to nominees on death. Deferred accumulation products, surrender-heavy wealth products and disguised tax-free bonds should remain outside the regime. Insurers should report exempt payouts through PAN-based tracking.

The direct revenue sacrifice would be real, but the wider fiscal economics could be favourable. If tax parity expands the retail annuity market, additional institutional capital flowing into long-dated central government

securities and SDLs could conservatively reach ₹40,000-50,000 crore annually. Even a modest 50-basis-point reduction in sovereign borrowing costs would generate recurring interest savings as the debt stock grows.

There is also a less visible fiscal benefit. Every retiree whose lifetime income is secured through an annuity is less vulnerable to exhausting savings and requiring emergency state support in old age. That reduction in future welfare liabilities has significant long-term economic value.

Implementation should be sequenced carefully. IRDAI should mandate inflation-linked annuity options, strengthen distributor controls and prescribe standardised yield disclosures. PFRDA should build a transparent platform for comparing annuity rates. Tax-deduction-at-source rules must also be aligned so that an exempt payment is not first taxed and only later reclaimed. India has already demonstrated that it is willing to exchange tax revenue for strategic capital. Capital-gains bonds and tax-free infrastructure bonds used precisely this mechanism: revenue foregone today in return for stable, directed financing of national priorities.

The annuity offers the same trade at greater scale and longer duration, while addressing an equally urgent priority: guaranteed lifetime income for an ageing population.

The government has proved twice that it can make this bargain. With the recent GST exemption, it has begun a third. What remains is to complete it: remove income tax on annuity income up to the threshold, put the annuity firmly on every retirement planner’s table, and allow India’s retail savings to fund both its retirees and its nation-building needs.

Kumar is the former Managing Director, and Sudhakar is former Executive Director, LIC. Views are personal

Gold loans: Inclusion engine or leverage trap?

Gold loans are often layered onto existing liabilities, suggesting they are a conduit for rising household leverage

Saumitra Bhaduri

Indian households’ fascination with gold seems insatiable. Estimates suggest that households hold between \$2.4 trillion and \$10 trillion worth of gold, by some measures exceeding annual GDP and accounting for nearly 65 per cent of non-property wealth.

For decades, economists have viewed this as a constraint on growth, as gold neither finances productive investment nor circulates through credit markets, and hence lacks the multiplier effects associated with other financial assets. It preserves wealth, but does not deploy it. Unlocking its macroeconomic potential, therefore, requires systematically channelling it into the formal economy. Even a gradual shift of a portion of this gold into financial channels through monetisation schemes, collateralised lending, and gold-linked savings instruments could have significant macroeconomic effects.

There have been signs of a promising shift. According to the RBI’s latest Financial Stability Report, gold loans have emerged as the fastest-growing segment of non-housing retail loans, driven by soaring gold prices and rising demand for secured borrowing. The segment has been growing at a CAGR of 42.4 per cent since March 2024, nearly twice the pace of overall non-housing

retail loans (23 per cent) during the same period. The report also noted that both banks and NBFCs have significantly expanded their gold loan portfolios in 2025-26, outpacing growth in other retail loan categories, including housing loans.

Therefore, it is no longer a niche product confined to informal markets. It is now mainstream, driven by banks, NBFCs and digital lending platforms. The expansion is not just in volume, but in scale and behaviour. Average ticket sizes have more than doubled, from about ₹90,000 in 2022 to nearly ₹2 lakh by 2025, while average outstanding per borrower has increased from roughly ₹1.9 lakh to ₹3.1 lakh. Thus, borrowers are not just entering the market but also taking larger and more frequent exposures.

POSITIVE SHIFTS

In addition, there are positive structural shifts. The borrower base is broadening, with an increasing share of prime and above-prime customers. Women borrowers are playing a significant role in driving growth, and newer geographies are emerging as key markets, indicating that the product is deepening financial inclusion.

At one level, this is exactly the sort of financialisation that should take shape. Instead of sitting idle, gold is being used as collateral to unlock credit. For those outside formal income systems, this



VALUE CREATION. India’s gold story is at an inflexion point GETTY IMAGES

provides a critical, relatively low-friction entry point to credit markets. Most importantly, it comes with significant macroeconomic upside. Even a gradual shift of gold into financial channels can have large effects. Some estimates suggest that channelling just 2 per cent of household gold annually into financial assets could add as much as \$7.5 trillion to GDP by 2047 through multiplier effects.

However, the trend may also entail emerging risks. The TransUnion CIBIL Gold Loan Landscape Report (April 2026) highlights some shifts in the borrower profile that complicate the narrative. It would be prudent to closely track emerging behavioural shifts.

By 2025, about 74 per cent of gold loan originations were to borrowers with more than ₹1 lakh in outstanding debt, up from roughly 50 per cent in 2022. At the same time, the share of borrowers

with unsecured credit exposure has increased, suggesting that gold loans are often layered onto existing liabilities rather than replacing them. The report also highlights a rise in repeat borrowing and multiple loan holdings. A growing proportion of customers now take concurrent gold loans, and the average number of active gold loan accounts per borrower has increased. This suggests that gold loans are becoming embedded in broader borrowing strategies rather than serving as one-off liquidity tools.

Most concerning is that borrowers with higher gold loan exposure have delinquency rates more than twice those of borrowers with lower gold loan exposure. Those with multiple active loans face the highest default risk, suggesting that leverage, not collateral, drives stress. Therefore, this duality defines the moment as gold loans are both a tool of financial inclusion and a conduit for rising household leverage.

India’s gold story is therefore at an inflexion point. The country has a unique asset base, one that few economies possess at this scale. The rise of gold loans offers a pathway to mobilise this wealth. Nonetheless, the same instrument that unlocks liquidity can also amplify risk. The challenge is to turn gold from a store of value to into a source of value creation without increasing systemic risk.

The writer is a Professor at Madras School of Economics

✉ **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to ‘Letters to the Editor’, The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Corporate performance

This refers to the editorial ‘Pleasant surprise’ (August 19). The resilience of India Inc, as noted in the editorial, is largely driven by domestic consumption, since Indian companies continue to face significant headwinds from unfavourable external factors such as US tariffs and the conflict in West Asia. Although rising energy costs pushed up the prices paid by end-users, companies are absorbing a portion

of the additional costs rather than passing the entire burden on to consumers. This cost absorption has eventually put pressure on corporate margins. Most importantly, India’s energy reserves have been one of the factors helping to contain pressure on domestic energy prices, even as several major economies have been forced to raise energy prices by 20-35 per cent.

S Lakshminarayanan
Ko. Puvanur & Post, TN

Credit-deposit dynamic

Apropos ‘Dynamics of deposit, credit growth’ (August 19), bank credit must grow in tandem with the underlying deposit base and productive demand. Excessive credit expansion can fuel inflation and asset-price imbalances, while inadequate credit can choke investment, consumption and economic growth. The need, therefore, is not maximum credit growth but the right quantum of credit, calibrated to deposit

mobilisation, liquidity conditions and genuine economic activity. A balanced credit-deposit dynamic will help banks support growth without compromising financial stability.

NR Nagarajan
Sivakasi, TN

Diversion of foreign funds

Apropos ‘IT Dept launches verification of 394 entities and 36 professionals for suspicious forex remittances’ (August 19), besides substantial forex remittance data

already in possession of the Income Tax Department through various sources and IT returns, the best and most credible investigation can be carried out by ground level physical verification by serving notices and summons. Income tax laws provide ample powers to reopen past cases. The diversion of foreign funds for ulterior motives is punishable in multiple laws and should be strictly dealt with.

Vinod Johri
Delhi

Reimagining tea sector

Empowering small growers can make it sustainable

Narendranath Dharmaraj

The Tamil Nadu tea industry has, for over a century, been an important contributor to the State’s economy, generating employment, supporting remote hill communities and shaping the unique landscape of the Nilgiris and adjoining regions. Today, however, the sector faces an unprecedented convergence of challenges. Unresolved land title disputes, expired lease agreements, concerns over afforestation and biodiversity conservation, declining estate profitability, fragmented smallholder production and the need to secure livelihoods have created a complex policy environment where conventional solutions are proving inadequate.

Legal disputes have been viewed separately from commercial viability; conservation priorities have often been seen as competing with production; and livelihood concerns have been addressed without adequately considering long-term land management. Such fragmented approaches inevitably lead to recurring conflicts, prolonged uncertainty and policy paralysis. The time has therefore come to adopt an integrated landscape approach that recognises tea estates not merely as production units, but as multifunctional landscapes delivering economic, social and environmental value. The objective should not be to choose between conservation and production, but to create systems in which both reinforce one another.

FIVE PRINCIPLES

A possible framework could rest on five key principles. First, decentralise land ownership or long-term cultivation rights, wherever feasible, in favour of existing workers and genuine small growers, thereby strengthening livelihood security and encouraging long-term investment in land stewardship. Second, establish professionally managed producer cooperatives or producer companies capable of providing technical services, quality management, input procurement, finance and collective marketing. Such institutions should combine community ownership with professional governance.

Third, enable existing estate companies to retain strategically important lands required for factories, warehousing, housing



TEA. Need for reformsSATHYAMOORTHY M

and essential infrastructure, while entering into long-term buyback agreements with grower institutions.

Tea should remain the dominant crop, but diversification into high-value horticultural, spice or agroforestry systems can strengthen resilience, improve incomes and reduce commercial risk. Finally, integrate ecological restoration into every stage of land-use planning.

Delivering this transformation will require supportive institutional and legal reforms. The government should constitute a high-level multi-stakeholder task force representing departments responsible for revenue, forests, agriculture, plantations, rural development, industry, financial institutions, worker organisations and the tea industry. This body should prepare a comprehensive implementation framework supported by appropriate legal and policy changes, simplified land administration procedures and incentives for sustainable land management. Implementation should be phased over five to seven years.

The first phase should focus on validation of land records, stakeholder consultations and preparation of landscape-level master plans. The second phase should establish pilot cooperative models, execute buy-back arrangements and initiate diversification and ecological restoration projects. The final phase should scale successful models across suitable tea-growing regions, supported by continuous monitoring, adaptive management and independent evaluation.

The government would achieve progress on environmental restoration, climate resilience and rural development objectives while reducing the burden of recurring disputes.

The writer is past President of the United Planters Association of Southern India



ABHAY SOBHANAN

Inside one of the world’s most automated distribution centres in Europe, a scene unfolds that still feels like science fiction. On top of a dense aluminium grid, squat robots glide in every direction, pause over a column, and burrow straight down into stacks of bins piled several deep, fishing out exactly the one an order needs and ferrying it to a waiting packing station. There are almost no people on the floor. The inventory that would sprawl across an Indian godown sits compressed into a fraction of the space, with the machines themselves forming the storage rack. This is the AutoStore-style “cube” warehouse, and walking through one, it is easy to believe the human order picker is already history.

It is tempting to look at that scene and conclude that the warehouse of the future is simply a warehouse with more machines in it. For India, in the middle of a warehousing boom driven by e-commerce and the bottleneck rise of ten-minute quick commerce, that conclusion would be both very expensive and slightly wrong.

Picture the warehouse most Indians actually rely on. A worker receives a pick-list, then walks the aisles (often 10-15 km over a shift) pushing a cart, hunting for items, and backtracking when a new order arrives or the pick-list gets updated. The bottleneck is rarely the building or the shelving. It is the choreography: who picks what, in which order, and along which path, while fresh orders keep landing every few seconds. That choreography is a decision problem, and decision problems are not solved by buying more hardware. They are solved by intelligence.

This distinction matters enormously for the country. The sophisticated robots in that gleaming European facility are extraordinary, but they are also capital-hungry and priced for markets where labour is scarce and expensive. India’s economics are the reverse. Most of the country’s warehouses are existing structures, capital is dear, and there is no shortage of workers. Simply transplanting a European cube warehouse wholesale is the least Indian solution imaginable.

INDIAN POTENTIAL

None of this is hypothetical. Indian fulfilment centres are already automating fast, and the country has produced genuine champions. India-born GreyOrange and Noida’s Addverb now ship goods-to-person robots and sortation systems to dozens of countries, with a newer generation of machines built specifically for the cramped dark stores behind quick commerce. What these firms market as



GETTY IMAGES

India’s unique warehouse advantage

LOGISTICS BRAIN. The future of order picking is being written in software as much as in hardware, and India already builds that software

their edge is the orchestration software: the ‘operating system’ that keeps machines, inventory, and people moving in sync. Notably, the hardware success stories are, at their core, selling a brain. The question is not whether the country automates, but whether it competes on that intelligence layer or merely buys someone else’s.

The more promising lever is the software that decides how the warehouse thinks. It is far cheaper, retrofittable, and largely invisible. In a recent study by the writer and collaborators, a self-learning system was built for “dynamic” order picking, where a picker must continuously re-plan their route as new orders stream in, rather than working off a fixed list. Using an artificial intelligence technique, the system learns from experience which sequence of moves keeps the most orders flowing. Under heavy demand, it lifted the share of orders fulfilled on

A distinctly Indian path to automation is not a wholesale swap of people for robots, but an intelligence layer laid over the warehouses, workers, and vehicles the country already has

time from roughly 82 per cent to about 98 per cent. No new robots, no new building. The gain came entirely from a better brain.

And order picking is only one operation among many. The same artificial intelligence toolkit is reshaping the unglamorous decisions that quietly govern logistics costs: where to place fast-moving items so pickers walk less, how to forecast the next hour’s demand so stock sits in the right location, how to route a fleet of delivery vehicles through real traffic, and, for the autonomous machines themselves, even when a robot should pause to recharge so the whole system never stalls. None of these requires ripping out a warehouse and rebuilding it. They require data and the algorithms to act on it.

This points to a distinctly Indian path to automation: not a wholesale swap of people for robots, but an intelligence layer laid over the warehouses, workers, and vehicles the country already has. A hybrid floor — where software directs human pickers more cleverly, and selective automation handles the densest, most repetitive zones — is likely to deliver more value per rupee here than a copy-paste of a European cube warehouse.

RESHAPING WORK

That hybrid future also reframes the question everyone asks first: what

happens to the jobs? Automation of this kind tends to reshape work more than it erases it, shifting people from walking and searching toward exception handling, machine supervision, and quality control, while creating new demand for technicians and data-literate floor managers. But “reshape, not erase” is only true if it is planned for. The warehousing sector is one of India’s largest new employers, and the reskilling has to be deliberate, not assumed. A worker displaced by a better algorithm is no comfort to that worker unless there is a clear path to the job the algorithm creates.

The National Logistics Policy set out to pull India’s logistics costs down toward global benchmarks, and the ten-minute delivery promise that millions of urban consumers now take for granted rests directly or indirectly on warehouses that can pick and pack with very little slack.

Both goals are, at heart, optimisation problems. India will not buy its way to them with hardware alone.

The right image of the Indian warehouse of the next decade, then, is not just a hall full of robots. It is an ordinary building that has quietly acquired a brain, one that the country would do well to build and operate.

The writer is Assistant Professor of Decision Sciences at IIM-Bangalore

thehindubusinessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

August 20, 2006

Lord Krishna Bank to merge with Centurion

A proposal to merge the Kerala based Lord Krishna Bank (LKB) with Centurion Bank of Punjab, was approved, in principle, by the boards of both the banks on Saturday. The merger will be subject to the approval of the Reserve Bank of India.

PM for more jobs in manufacturing

The Prime Minister, Dr Manmohan Singh, on Saturday assured trade union leaders of his Government’s commitment to labour welfare and stressed the need to create more jobs outside agriculture, particularly manufacturing. “While we are taking all possible steps for the growth of agriculture, we need to create jobs elsewhere, particularly in manufacturing,” he said.

HCL to invest Rs 500 cr on three new SEZs

HCL Technologies Ltd will invest Rs 500 crore for building three Special Economic Zones in the country. The investment is part of the Rs 800-crore capital expenditure that HCL plans to make in the next two years. The company is expected to ramp up its employee base by 10,000 this year and by 35,000 over the next two to three years.

Trump delays Canada tariffs at last minute after tentative deal

Alicia Diaz
Josh Wingrove

The Trump administration delayed 50 per cent tariffs on billions of dollars of Canadian products for three days, saying the two sides had reached a tentative agreement to resolve a broader trade dispute that had plunged relations to a fresh low.

US President Donald Trump announced the decision less than two hours before the tariffs were set to take effect.

He said on social media he was pausing the tariffs “based on the fact that Canada and the U.S.A., subject to the finalization of documents, have a DEAL!”

A White House proclamation later said the duties were halted after Canada “expressed a commitment to

remove the discriminations” on US autos, dairy and alcohol.

And the US Trade Representative’s office said the deal includes “comprehensive market access for all American goods, economic security commitments, digital trade alignment” and other factors, without giving specifics.

Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney wasn’t as definitive, stopping short of saying they had a deal. Neither side said whether earlier sticking points such as auto tariffs and lumber will be resolved.

“Substantial progress has been made, although there is important work still to be done,” Carney said in a statement.

“While we continue this work, Canada remains focused on building a stronger, more independent, and more competitive economy at home.”



ON HOLD. US tariffs GETTY IMAGES

Despite the uncertainty, the announcement signals progress in the tense relationship between two longstanding allies that conducted almost \$900 billion of trade with each other last year.

It also indicates the potential for a step forward in the ongoing review of the North American trade agreement, which also includes Mexico.

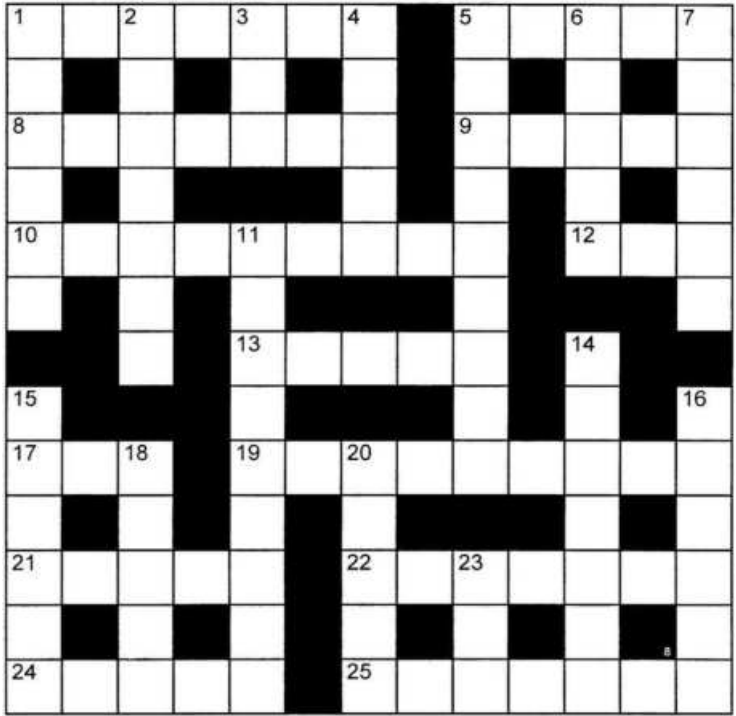
Trump had announced the tariffs in

late July, justifying them by pointing to Canada’s retaliation against a barrage of tariffs last year, and it wasn’t immediately clear what concessions he’d won from the latest gambit. He has routinely backed off some of his biggest tariff threats when negotiations yield what are often modest concessions.

The White House had said it would put duties on a range on items from Canada — including hockey equipment, beer, milk and plywood — under Section 338 of the 1930 Tariff Act, which gives the US President the power to impose duties of as much as 50 per cent on countries deemed to discriminate against US commerce.

Most Canadian provinces, including Ontario and Quebec, have barred US alcoholic beverages from retail stores, cutting off an important export market for American makers of wine and spirits. BLOOMBERG

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2718



EASY

ACROSS

- 01. Case for display (7)
- 05. Boatswain (5)
- 08. Ill-ventilated, stuffy (7)
- 09. Circus performer (5)
- 10. A seasoning (9)
- 12. Rug (3)
- 13. Paved area in garden (5)
- 17. To employ (3)
- 19. Feeling affronted (9)
- 21. Theatricality (5)
- 22. Irritating (7)
- 24. To cast out (5)
- 25. Turbulent flow of water (7)

DOWN

- 01. Probability (6)
- 02. Lowest British hereditary title (7)
- 03. Born (giving maiden name) (3)
- 04. Try for flavour (5)
- 05. Shrub with berries giving sap-green (9)
- 06. Violent weather (5)
- 07. Four score and ten (6)
- 11. Of much consequence (9)
- 14. Illegally placed on football field (7)
- 15. Bewilderment (6)
- 16. Act of fleeing (6)
- 18. Rub out (5)
- 20. Rapid (5)
- 23. Limousine (3)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

- 01. A case of pudding being served at Number Ten perhaps (7)
- 05. Who’s the piper on board? (5)
- 08. It’s as stuffy as a vacuum must be (7)
- 09. A comic entertainer in a chic, low nightclub (5)
- 10. Seasoning consisting of mint, once, with a touch of dill (9)
- 12. Become entangled with a kneeler (3)
- 13. A top one spins in the paved area by the house (5)
- 17. Among various employers it’s the custom (3)
- 19. How runt feels about bearing a grudge (9)
- 21. A right, mad mixture of theatrical entertainment (5)
- 22. Having a teasing desire for gin, chit may turn to it (7)
- 24. Don’t accept that one must lose head to throw one out (5)
- 25. An outpouring of words in a rushing stream (7)

DOWN

- 01. This may be one’s opportunity to take a risk (6)
- 02. Rank given to Bartholomew shortly? (7)
- 03. Being born a woman, has no end of want (3)
- 04. What the tongue perceives to be to one’s liking (5)
- 05. He-rabbit turns north seeing this shrub (9)
- 06. Make a direct assault in violent weather (5)
- 07. Number starting ten years of naughtiness? (6)
- 11. Trip to Man is organised, as it matters (9)
- 14. Football infringement that’s to the right of the driver (7)
- 15. The confusion the wet earth may have led to (6)
- 16. Some steps taken where aviation is concerned (6)
- 18. Some teacher, as expected, will wipe it out (5)
- 20. He was quick writing A Tale of a Tub (5)
- 23. Roughly, it’s right to be one’s personal transport (3)

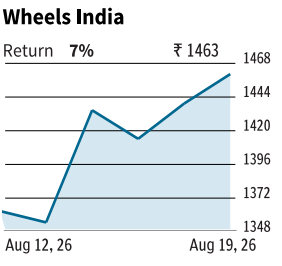
SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2717

ACROSS 1. Basil 4. Scallop 8. About 9. Tempura 10. Dye 11. Stainless 12. Nest 13. Path 18. Herbalism 20. Off 21. Ululate 22. Ochre 23. Elegant 24. Hired

DOWN 1. Boarding house 2. Showers 3. Latest 4. Satrap 5. Almond 6. Lounge 7. Plays the field 14. Another 15. Banana 16. Direct 17. Smooth 19. Route

QUICKLY.

Wheels India approves pref issue of ₹180 crore



Chennai: The board of Wheels India approved the preferential issue on a private-placement basis for an aggregate consideration of ₹180 crore. It has approved the issue of “an aggregate of up to 12,69,391 shares having face value of ₹10 each at an issue price of ₹1,418 a share for cash consideration aggregating up to ₹180 crore,” a stock exchange filing said. The allottees include TSF Investments, Srivats Ram, Nivedita Ram and Gita Ram. The board also approved seeking shareholders’ approval for enhancement of fund raising limits from ₹400 crore to ₹450 crore. **OUR BUREAU**

Madhur Knit to raise ₹53 cr via NSE Emerge IPO

Mumbai: Madhur Knit Crafts plans to raise ₹53 crore through an IPO on the NSE Emerge platform. The company will issue 53.27 lakh shares in the price band of ₹95-100. The issue will open for subscription on Monday. The proceeds from the IPO will be used for the purchase of solar panels, repayment of certain outstanding borrowings and the general corporate purposes. Arun Gupta, promoter and MD, Madhur Knit Crafts, said over the years, the firm had built an integrated textile manufacturing platform with capabilities spanning yarn processing to finished fabrics and textile products. **OUR BUREAU**

Working on easing SME listing framework, says SEBI Chairman

HOLISTIC REVIEW. To consider changes in norms for market-making, underwriting and paid-up capital

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India is working on a comprehensive review of the small and medium enterprise (SME) listing framework to address difficulties with the existing rules related to trading, migration to mainboard, market-making and underwriting. Speaking on the sidelines of the annual Ficci Capital Markets Conference on Wednesday, SEBI Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey said, “There are certain things about the SME framework which are actually curbing the organisations and enterprises that are on the SME platform. They are curbing their growth, and there are

difficulties in their trading as well.” SEBI has observed a lot of odd lots being created, which has made it difficult for investors to trade. The market-making and underwriting frameworks mandated for SMEs are not working properly and are only adding to the costs, making SME IPOs costlier than the mainboard, he said. Further, migration to the mainboard has been linked to the paid-up capital of companies, which is creating issues and needs to be de-linked and rethought in a new way. A consultation paper on the same will be issued, he said. SEBI is also preparing guidelines for the responsible use of technology, and accountability during the use of artificial intelligence (AI)



IN REFORM MODE. (from left) Ficci Senior V-P and Sanmar Group’s Chairman Vijay Sankar, SEBI Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey and NSE CEO Ashish Kumar Chauhan at Ficci’s Capital Markets Conference in Mumbai on Wednesday **ANI**

and machine learning (ML) in financial markets.

AI TO BE ACCOUNTABLE “Technologies are there, and we will certainly help in AI technology to be facilitated,

but then we must have responsibility and accountability more clearly outlined,” Pandey said. Every SEBI-regulated entity would remain fully responsible for any AI or ML

Regulator will initiate strict, immediate action against CAS manipulators

Our Bureau
Mumbai

SEBI will take strict and immediate action against any attempt to manipulate the closing auction session (CAS) to defame it, said Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey. “We want to make one thing clear, that if people do manipulation in CAS, then we will take strict action and do it immediately... if someone thinks they will manipulate CAS to defame it, they are mistaken,” Pandey said on the sidelines of the Ficci Capital Markets Conference.

The CAS system has more transparency than the earlier VWAP-based system, and it gives the regulator greater capability to detect manipulation. Further, the regulator is looking at the constraints of participation. The mutual funds and prop traders have increased participation, he said. **AFTER MARKET ORDERS** SEBI has also asked brokers to start accepting after-market orders (AMOs) during the five-minute transition period before CAS between 3.15 pm and 3.20 pm to improve liquidity, said people aware of the discussions.

This would require technological changes to the brokers’ trading systems and processes, which are at different stages for different brokers, they said. “Starting September, we should be able to start accepting AMO orders between 3.15 pm and 3.20 pm to help in price discovery,” said Dhiraj Relli, MD & CEO, HDFC Securities. The CAS is a 20-minute auction window that begins at 3.15 pm after continuous trading ends and is used to determine the closing levels of F&O stocks through order matching. Currently, orders are not taken from 3.15 pm to 3.20 pm.

Foreign capital, corporate bond market are key priorities for DEA, says Alok Tiwari

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The government is working to attract foreign capital and deepen India’s corporate bond market, with both emerging as key priorities for the Department of Economic Affairs (DEA), Joint Secretary Alok Tiwari said on Wednesday. Speaking at the Ficci Capital Markets conference in Mumbai, Tiwari said, “Foreign capital has not been very forthcoming, of late. Though the cycle appears to have turned in July, there are still some hiccups.” “If India has to grow to be-

come an important financial centre and provide resources for Viksit Bharat, we need domestic capital as well as foreign capital. Foreign capital has to be welcomed, attracted...,” he said. **‘BROAD CONSENSUS’** Tiwari said there is a “broad consensus” within the government, regulators and market participants on the need to attract foreign capital, and it is “a work in progress”. The government is also seeking to facilitate foreign investment by streamlining the statutory architecture, he said. “Foreign exchange man-



Alok Tiwari, Joint Secretary, DEA

agement, foreign investment rules are being recast. They are open to public consultation right now by the Reserve Bank of India.” “We hope to make it more principle-based, easier to follow and easier to navigate,”

buying and domestic capital rotation. HCL Tech and JSW Steel were among the top individual gainers. Energy, FMCG, Defence and Media bore the brunt of the selling, with defence stocks falling over 1.5 per cent. Max Health and Coal India ended as the session’s top losers. Sugar stocks, however, bucked the trend, gaining up to 10 per cent as global raw sugar prices touched a 14-month high and domestic prices rose on tight supplies and festive demand expectations. City gas distributors Indraprastha Gas and Mahanagar Gas gained 3-4 per cent, following government incentives to boost domestic piped-gas connections. The broader market, too, saw modest but wider losses. The Nifty Midcap 100 declined 0.21 per cent while the Nifty Smallcap 100 fell 0.51 per cent, though both continue to outperform the benchmarks.

Behari Lal Engg ends up 76% at ₹502.20 on day 1 of listing



STELLAR SHOW. (from left) Lovlish Garg, Whole-time Director; Rajesh Garg, Vice-Chairman, and Dinesh Garg, MD, Behari Lal Engineering, at the listing ceremony

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Shares of Behari Lal Engineering Ltd (BLEL) made a strong stock market debut on Wednesday, listing at ₹465 on the NSE, a 63.1 per cent premium over the IPO issue price of ₹285. On the BSE, the stock opened at ₹458, up 60.7 per cent and closed at ₹502.55, a gain of 76.33 per cent. The stock closed at ₹502.2 on the NSE, up 76.2 per cent over the issue price, after touching an intra-day high of ₹537. Total traded value on the NSE stood at ₹1,883.61 crore, with 376.18 lakh shares changing hands. The

₹302-crore IPO was subscribed 108.44 times. The issue comprised a fresh issue of ₹93 crore and an OFS of ₹209 crore. Proceeds from the fresh issue are earmarked for capital expenditure at the company’s two existing facilities in Mandi Gobindgarh, Punjab, and partial debt repayment. **BELOW PEER AVERAGE** Shivani Nyati, Head of Wealth at Swastika Investment, said the IPO was priced at 18.7x FY26 earnings, below the peer average of roughly 31x, which contributed to the strong listing. Nyati advised allotted investors to consider booking partial profits.

Shiprocket ends 47.5% higher on debut day

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Shiprocket made a strong stock market debut on Wednesday, with shares listing at ₹131 on the NSE and ₹129.50 on the BSE, representing premiums of 35 per cent and 33.5 per cent respectively over the IPO price of ₹97. The shares closed the first day of trading at ₹143.45 on the NSE, a gain of 47.53 per cent over the IPO issue price of ₹97, as strong investor demand drove the stock to an intra-day high of ₹156 before it settled lower. The listing was broadly in line with grey market expectations, which pointed to a premium of around 36 per cent ahead of the debut. The Gurugram-based e-commerce logistics and shipping platform had priced its IPO at the upper end of the ₹92-97 band, raising ₹1,617 crore. The issue comprised a fresh issue worth ₹885.5 crore and an offer for sale of ₹731.98 crore by existing shareholders.

BROKER’S CALL.

Jefferies

BELRISE INDUSTRIES (BUY) Target: ₹280 CMP: ₹233 Belrise, in the last two quarters, faced cost pressures from higher commodity and fuel prices, and increased transportation and labour costs. It believes that the worst of the cost pressures are now factored in, and retained its guidance of FY27 margins to be similar to FY26. Belrise has historically demonstrated low margin volatility, delivering EBITDA margins in a 12-14 per cent range over FY21-26. The company secured multiple new orders in Q1, including: a chassis order from a fast-growing 2W/3W OEM; two new OEM additions for braking and suspension; and an EV localisation programme from a leading Indian 4W OEM for a high-selling EV model, covering 59 assemblies, tooling, fixtures and automation. Belrise is also expanding its non-auto footprint with a new order in renewable for sheet metal assemblies from a leading US solar tracker OEM with peak revenue potential of over ₹150 crore. With the two recent acquisitions in France and the UK, Belrise has also entered into global aerospace components supply chain. We cut FY27 EPS by a slight 3per cent, and broadly retain FY28-29 estimates. We expect strong 21 per cent EBITDA and 25 per cent EPS CAGR over FY26-29E, including the earnings accretion from the merger of group entities in FY28. Its 29x one-year forward PE appears rich, but we believe justified for healthy growth and an expanding business footprint. We maintain Buy with revised ₹280 PT based on 27x September 2028 PE (earlier ₹250 based on 26x FY28E PE).

Elara Securities

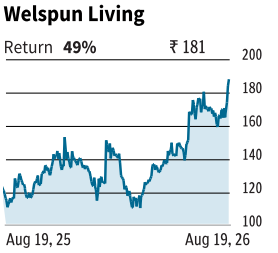
PRAJ INDUSTRIES (SELL) Target: ₹285 CMP: ₹340.70 Q1-FY27 continues to highlight the gap between Praj Industries’ long-term growth initiatives and its near-term earnings contribution. Consolidated revenue increased 11.8 per cent year on year to ₹720 crore, led by growth in bioenergy and HiPurity, while engineering remains subdued and domestic first-generation ethanol execution continues to be affected by weak greenfield activity, customer funding constraints, and slower backlog conversion. The rise in share of the African Union market exports revenue with lower realisation and margin vs the EU and the Americas. Despite weak operating leverage, PAT was up 117.3 per cent to ₹11.6 crore, supported by higher Other income and lower interest cost. Order intake rebound to ₹1,000 crore in Q1FY27, up 25.8 per cent, driven by the international markets and newer applications, with exports contributing 43 per cent of Q1 intake and a marquee 800-klpd corn-to-ethanol order from Brazil. While the company is expanding into newer businesses, these opportunities remain in the nascent stage and are yet to meaningfully offset weakness in the core business. Continued project delays, subdued operating leverage, and ongoing investments in GenX are likely to keep profitability under pressure in the near term. The management’s lack of margin guidance reflects limited visibility on the pace of recovery. We retain Sell with a TP of ₹285 based on 27x FY28E P/E.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: **blmarketwatch@gmail.com**

TODAY’S PICK.

Welspun Living (₹181.25): BUY

Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau



The short-term outlook is bullish for Welspun Living. The stock has been in a strong uptrend since April this year. Within that, the share price has seen a mild correction over the last month. The 10 per cent rise so far this week indicates that the corrective fall has ended, and the broader uptrend has resumed. Support is in the ₹170-168 region, which could limit the downside. Welspun Living share price could rise to ₹205 in the coming weeks. Traders can buy the shares now at ₹181. Accumulate on dips at ₹174. Keep the stop-loss at ₹164. Trail the

stop-loss higher to ₹185 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹189. Revise the stop-loss further up to ₹190 and ₹196 when the price touches ₹194 and ₹199 respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹203. Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

24110 » Nifty 50 Futures

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
24090	24000	24160	24240	Go short only below 24090. Stop-loss can be placed at 24110

₹721 » HDFC Bank

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
715	711	725	729	Go short now and at 724. Keep the stop-loss at 726

₹1120 » Infosys

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1110	1080	1130	1150	Go short only below 1110. Keep the stop-loss at 1115

₹267 » ITC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
265	260	269	271	Go long on a bounce from 265 with a stop-loss at 265

₹238 » ONGC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
237	234	240	243	Take fresh shorts below 237. Keep the stop-loss at 238

₹1307 » Reliance Ind.

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1295	1270	1320	1330	Wait for dips. Go long at 1298. Keep the stop-loss at 1290

₹1044 » SBI

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1040	1030	1055	1075	Go short only below 1030. Keep the stop-loss at 1034

₹2287 » TCS

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2255	2220	2305	2350	Go short now and on a rise at 2398. Keep the stop-loss at 2310

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers					▼ 76.60 pts.
	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN%	
Eternal Ltd.	320.00	6.48	713.19	2.10	
HCL Tech	1324.80	6.17	20.62	1.27	
Sun Pharma	1900.00	5.76	37.62	1.83	
Kotak Bank	390.25	4.18	19.12	2.61	
JSW Steel	1285.80	3.73	11.23	1.09	
Infosys	1119.80	3.68	14.98	3.56	
TCS	2289.00	2.01	16.55	2.12	
Titan	5068.00	1.75	78.11	1.90	
Bajaj Auto	11645.00	0.92	28.17	1.17	
Tata Consumer/Product	1068.00	0.91	64.36	0.63	
Wipro	179.55	0.88	13.39	0.44	
Trent Ltd.	2953.00	0.79	86.77	0.89	
NestleIndia	1465.00	0.39	74.12	0.95	
Asian Paints	2630.80	0.24	52.17	1.08	
SBI Life	1780.40	0.24	68.67	0.73	
Bajaj Finserv	2012.00	0.10	15.60	1.06	
MM	1389.00	-0.03	30.03	1.62	
Adani Ports	1681.90	-0.08	29.53	1.13	
Tech Mahindra	1589.80	-0.31	30.18	0.92	
HDFC Life	536.30	-0.46	58.59	0.52	
NTPC	336.55	-0.57	11.52	1.45	
Tata Motors PV	321.30	-0.69	0.00	0.61	
Grochim Ind.	3270.50	-0.72	19.56	1.31	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1106.00	-0.73	22.99	1.41	
Adani Enter	2990.30	-0.77	51.78	0.78	
Eicher Motors	7990.50	-0.84	38.00	1.00	
Hindalco	1038.95	-0.84	14.24	1.37	
Cipla	1422.00	-1.12	34.23	0.73	
Jr Reddys Lab	117.00	-1.17	30.68	0.85	
MAH	2415.00	-1.27	20.98	2.77	
ONGC	238.00	-1.27	6.68	0.84	
UltraTech Cement	11450.00	-1.27	39.37	1.23	
Int'lGlobeAvi	5193.00	-1.34	0.00	1.07	
Apollo Hosp	8750.00	-1.51	57.92	0.82	
Jo Financial Services Ltd.	243.15	-1.90	77.69	0.72	
Bharti Elec	429.08	-2.10	48.13	1.33	
Tata Steel	184.00	-2.71	20.39	1.38	
Hind Unilever	2020.70	-2.77	45.24	1.63	
Max Healthcare	997.00	-2.83	66.58	0.67	
Coal India	400.00	-3.61	7.90	0.87	
State Bank	1048.60	-3.97	10.79	3.93	
PowerGrid Corp	243.15	-4.45	15.42	1.08	
Axis Bank	1235.00	-5.02	13.75	3.22	
L&T	4041.30	-5.88	28.33	4.29	
ITC	267.05	-6.21	16.58	2.34	
Bharti Airtel	1922.00	-8.11	32.16	5.30	
Bajaj Finance	1080.20	-8.26	32.57	2.63	
HDFC Bank	720.00	-10.04	13.44	10.01	
ICICI Bank	1402.00	-14.61	16.82	3.11	
Reliance Ind	1311.00	-16.24	20.12	8.04	

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers

▼ 408.25 pts.

	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN%
Tata Motors Cv	478.30	40.36	42.07	3.93
Torrent Pharma	5013.00	17.90	88.44	2.89
Bajaj Holdings	11380.00	15.85	14.08	1.94
Hdfc Amc	2551.70	15.82	37.11	2.05
Jindal Steel	1115.00	14.53	41.99	1.62
Indian Hotels Co.	723.35	11.10	44.60	2.50
Punjab Natl Bank	117.48	9.81	6.10	1.59
Union Bank	186.90	7.86	6.91	1.42
Df	669.90	7.74	37.30	3.69
Chelamandalamini&Fin	1873.50	6.91	17.77	3.19
Bank Of Baroda	245.00	5.39	6.89	1.79
Tata Capital	365.55	3.51	28.33	0.72
Tvs Motor Cmp .	4361.10	2.94	57.53	4.03
United Spirits .	1524.00	2.66	65.71	1.77
Ltimindtree	4564.40	0.59	26.05	1.67
Power Finance	374.45	0.00	3.67	2.14
Canara Bank	129.08	-0.20	5.90	1.71
Macrotech Developers .	1210.00	-0.89	29.28	1.32
Godrej Consumer	930.00	-1.17	49.73	1.47
Hindus Zinc	557.00	-1.40	13.79	1.05
Samvardhamothersinternat	170.29	-1.41	39.46	2.96
Hyundai Motor India .	2174.50	-4.77	35.69	1.22
Mazagon Dock .	2563.80	-5.12	36.24	0.77
Indian Railway Finance Corp	85.18	-5.44	15.48	0.67
Rural Elec	337.00	-5.44	5.53	1.66
Bosch	48460.00	-6.81	60.48	1.65
Vedanta	262.60	-6.90	6.15	1.75
AvenueSuper	3965.00	-7.49	84.58	2.51
Gail (India)	172.50	-7.84	11.49	1.83
Zykluslifesciences	1104.50	-8.07	24.20	1.09
Ambuja Cements	407.50	-8.88	19.52	1.00
Tata Power	378.90	-10.18	23.03	2.49
Divis Lab	8560.00	-10.34	77.69	4.28
MuthootFin	2859.00	-10.94	10.02	1.21
Britannia Ind	5453.00	-14.38	50.32	2.53
AdaniGreenenergy	1293.00	-14.61	99.25	1.70
Siemens	3389.00	-14.93	95.57	3.36
Shree Cement	24340.00	-14.96	53.68	1.28
Indian Oilcorp	136.30	-16.29	5.39	2.00
Abb India	7430.00	-17.69	101.24	1.53
Adani Power .	204.02	-18.81	27.07	3.33
Bpcl	307.00	-19.44	7.77	2.45
Pidilitt	1650.00	-21.61	62.75	2.21
Varun Energy India .	3463.00	-38.32	63.36	1.21
Purav Beverages	431.85	-29.60	42.84	2.02
Starline Industries	19721.00	-39.57	87.03	1.89
Hindustanaironautics	501.00	-45.21	36.00	3.74
Cummins India	5220.00	-51.03	61.13	2.77
Adani Energy Solutions .	1540.70	-59.66	58.89	1.99
Cg Power & Ind Sol	863.05	-62.07	109.78	2.33

Pts: Impact on index movement

QUICKLY.

Investcorp acquires
20Cube 3PL for ₹500 cr

Mumbai: Global alternative investment firm Investcorp on Wednesday said it has acquired digital-first contract logistics platform 20Cube 3PL Solutions for about ₹500 crore, a move that will help the logistics firm accelerate its technology capabilities, and expand pan-India network, among others. In addition, 20Cube and Investcorp will seek to invest another ₹500-750 crore to acquire synergistic contract logistics businesses, it said. **m**

KKR to buy minority
stake in BookMyShow

New Delhi: Global investment firm KKR said it has signed definitive agreements to acquire a minority stake in BookMyShow. While the financial details of the transaction were not disclosed, the investment is aimed at supporting BookMyShow's growth as it scales its live entertainment business and deepens its full-stack offering across India. **m**

IDFC First Bank
raises \$500 m via
3-yr senior notes

Our Bureau
Mumbai

IDFC First Bank has raised \$500 million through its maiden three-year fixed-rate senior notes due 2029 via its IFSC Banking Unit at GIFT City.

The private sector bank, in a statement, said the notes carry a fixed coupon of 5.625 per cent and were placed with investors outside the US in Regulation S format.

"This is the bank's first international bond issuance and marks its entry into the global debt capital markets," the bank said. The transaction follows the assignment of an investment-grade 'BBB-' long-term issuer credit rating with a Stable outlook by S&P Global Ratings on August 13, it added.

The transaction was anchored by global institutional investors, including BlackRock, Capital Group and Alliancebernstein.

Symbiotec Pharmalab to
launch ₹1,757 cr IPO on Sept 1

FACT SHEET. Co fixes price band at ₹938-988, to raise ₹150 crore via fresh issue

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Symbiotec Pharmalab, a leading pharma and biotech company, plans to raise ₹1,757 crore through an initial public offering (IPO).

The price band has been fixed at ₹938-988 per equity share, valuing the company at around ₹6,350 crore at the higher end. The IPO will open for subscription on Monday. The equity shares are proposed to be listed on both the BSE and NSE on September 1.

Bids can be made for a minimum of 15 equity shares and in multiples of 15 shares thereafter.

The issue comprises a fresh issue of equity shares worth up to ₹150 crore and an offer for sale of shares aggregating up to ₹1,607 crore. Promoter Satwani Holdings LLP will be offloading ₹144 crore-worth shares, while investors Rosewood Investments and Motilal Oswal



USE OF FUNDS. Proceeds from the fresh issue will be utilised for debt repayment and general corporate purposes

Private Equity-backed India Business Excellence Fund-III will be selling shares worth ₹988 crore and ₹475 crore, respectively. Rosewood Investments and India Business Excellence Fund-III are the largest shareholders in the company with 34.78 per cent and 24.16 per cent stakes, respectively, while the promoters had 36.4 per cent shareholding, as per the red herring prospectus filed on August 18.

The company intends to use the proceeds from the

fresh issue for debt repayment and general corporate purposes.

CDMO PLAYER

The company operates as a contract development and manufacturing organisation for specialty pharmaceutical and nutraceutical companies globally, offering products and services across three platforms — organic chemistry, biotechnology and complex injectables.

It also manufactures its own products across the

Proofpoint expands in India by establishing a
Hyderabad CoE, to hire more than 200 engineers

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

Proofpoint is stepping up its India focus, as enterprises accelerate AI adoption and seek to secure employees, AI agents and sensitive data, with the cybersecurity company planning to hire more than 200 engineers over the next two years and expand its local go-to-market presence.

As part of the expansion, Proofpoint is setting up an AI Security Engineering Centre of Excellence (CoE) in Hyderabad that will focus on AI security technologies, including capabilities related to AI governance, runtime protection and security for AI applications, co-pilots and autonomous agents. These capabilities build on technology from Acuvity, which Proofpoint recently acquired.

The company has about 100 employees in India, in addition to more than 550 extended team members at its Pune CoE. It also has go-to-market hubs in Delhi and Bengaluru, and is opening another office in Delhi.

"India is at an interesting point where enterprises are adopting technology and AI at a healthy pace. There is no real scepticism or pause; companies understand both the benefits of AI and the larger risk surface it creates," Sumit Dhawan, CEO of Proofpoint, said.

"When you combine that with evolving privacy requirements and the compliance needs of regulated industries, we believe we can be a strong partner for Indian enterprises as they adopt AI while ensuring that their data remains protected and compliant," he added.

Recent customer-wins in India include one of the



Sumit Dhawan, CEO of Proofpoint

country's largest private sector banks, along with customers in the BFSI, BPO, defence and public sectors. Dhawan said the decision to expand Proofpoint's engineering footprint in India is closely linked to the changing nature of AI-driven security threats.

AI-FOCUSED COE

"We decided to expand our presence in India through an AI-focused CoE because being closer to customers allows us to work with them on

developing the right intent-based models," he added.

The Hyderabad centre will focus on developing models that can understand intent and help secure AI agents and other AI-driven technologies. Proofpoint plans to build the centre with specialists in data science and AI who can develop these models and work closely with customers already deploying AI. "The US and two or three other countries are ahead of India in terms of the interest in and speed of AI adoption. But when you look at both AI adoption and awareness of the importance of securing AI, India would be among the top five markets," he said.

The company's India business has tripled over the past 12 months, while new customer acquisition has grown at a double-digit rate.

The company is also expanding its data and AI capabilities in India, as enter-

Prosus to invest \$100 million in
Navi in first institutional fundraise

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Fintech company Navi has announced a \$100-million investment from global technology investor Prosus, marking the company's first institutional capital raise and strengthening its position as it looks to scale its digital financial services businesses.

The transaction is subject to customary closing conditions and regulatory approvals, including clearance from the Competition Commission of India (CCI).

The investment will deepen the relationship between Navi Founder and Executive Chairman Sachin Bansal and Prosus, which dates back more than a decade through Naspers and the Prosus Group.

Bansal said the investment was a "strong endorsement" of the institution Navi is building and that the company would benefit from Prosus' global perspective, long-term approach and experience in scaling technology businesses.

Ashutosh Sharma, Head of Prosus India Investments



The investment
comes as Navi
enters its next
phase of growth
with improving
operating metrics
across payments
and lending

and M&A, said Navi demonstrated several qualities that the investor looks for, including a large base of loyal users, multiple business lines, a technology-first approach and a focus on consumer experience.

IMPROVED METRICS

The investment comes as Navi enters its next phase of growth with improving operating metrics across payments and lending.

During FY26, Navi UPI retained its position as India's fourth-largest UPI applica-

tion, while Navi Finserv's assets under management crossed ₹13,000 crore.

The group also reported consolidated profitability in the fourth quarter of FY26, which Navi said reflected improving economics and increasing operating leverage across its businesses.

SCALE SERVICES

For Prosus, the investment adds another Indian fintech exposure to its portfolio as the sector matures beyond payments towards lending and broader financial services.

For Navi, the capital comes at a significant point as it seeks to scale its technology-led financial services platform while maintaining profitability.

Unlike several Indian fintech companies that have relied on multiple rounds of institutional funding to scale, Navi has largely been built under Bansal's ownership.

The Prosus investment, therefore, marks a shift in its capital structure while giving the company an institutional investor with experience in backing technology businesses over the long term.

US green card seekers to face
new hurdles from Sept 18

Press Trust of India
Washington

Immigrants seeking green cards or permanent residency in the US will face fresh hurdles as the Trump administration has expanded the definition of "public charge" to deny applications to those availing benefits such as Medicaid, food stamps or any subsistence aid from the government.

The new rule, finalised by the US Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS), comes into effect from September 18 and will also hit Indians seeking green cards.

An earlier rule only considered two types of public benefits as grounds for deny-

ing a green card application — cash assistance for income maintenance and long-term institutionalisation at the government's expense.

"USCIS officers will consider the five statutory factors and any other factor relevant to assessing the alien's likelihood at any time of becoming a public charge, including the alien's receipt of means-tested public benefits, such as cash assistance for income maintenance, housing assistance, food stamps, financial aid for college, or any other similar benefit," an official statement said.

The guidance follows the Department of Homeland Security's decision to rescind the 2022 Biden-era public charge regulations.

Novonesis to roll out ₹3,000-crore investment
in Maharashtra over the next 24-36 months

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Danish bio-solutions major Novonesis plans to roll out its proposed ₹2,500-3,000 crore investment in Maharashtra over the next 24-36 months, with its Patalganga manufacturing site set to be a key beneficiary, as the company expands capacity to tap growing demand for bio-fuels, food and health solutions and agricultural biologicals in India.

The company expects remaining approvals and sign-offs for the Maharashtra project to be completed this year, following which investment details will be announced.

"The ₹2,500-3,000 crore that we talked about in India is over two-three years,"



Krishna Mohan Puvvada, Regional President - Middle East, India and Africa

Krishna Mohan Puvvada, Regional President-Middle East, India and Africa, Novonesis, said. The company signed an MoU with the Maharashtra government earlier this year.

PATALGANGA FACILITY

A significant part of the expansion is expected at Patalganga, where Novonesis has

a facility and substantial land available for additional capacity. "We are looking towards the Patalganga part, where we can leverage more, because only 10 per cent of the overall land has been utilised," Puvvada said.

Novonesis also operates at Wada in Maharashtra. Its Indian plants manufacture enzymes and health and nutrition ingredients, including products for export.

BIOFUEL OPPORTUNITY

Novonesis supplies enzymes, yeast and other biological technologies to ethanol manufacturers to improve yields, shorten fermentation cycles and lower energy consumption. "We are not involved in biofuel production. We work with ethanol manufacturers who then sell to OMCs," Puvvada said.

The company says newer yeast technologies can reduce fermentation time by about 25 per cent, cutting energy requirements and production risks while improving yields.

Novonesis recently launched a biological solution in Karnataka that it says can increase sugarcane yields by about 15 per cent, potentially improving feedstock economics for ethanol producers.

The company is also working with organised players in India's emerging biogas ecosystem. Trials using different substrates have shown output improvements ranging from over 15 per cent to 25-30 per cent in some cases.

Puvvada, however, identified regulation as a key constraint, particularly in agriculture.

Responsible AI must expand inclusion: RBI Deputy Guv

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Reserve Bank of India (RBI) Deputy Governor Shirish Chandra Murmu has urged banks to use artificial intelligence (AI) not just to improve efficiency but to expand financial inclusion and strengthen customer trust.

Speaking at the CNBC-TV18 Banking Transformation Summit, he said AI offers a major opportunity to identify deserving borrowers outside the formal credit system and bring them into the banking fold.

Murmu noted that banks are well-capitalised, profit-

able and resilient. However, he cautioned that the success of banking should not be measured solely by balance sheet growth. Instead, the focus should be on how effectively financial services reach underserved customers and support broader economic development.

ACCESS TO CREDIT

He said alternative data sources such as cash flows, GST filings, utility payments, mobile usage and geospatial information can help banks assess borrowers who lack traditional credit histories. He stressed that AI should be used to widen access to credit rather than

simply improve services for existing customers.

He also warned against excessive reliance on algorithms, emphasising that human judgment remains essential. Bank boards and senior management, he said, must retain accountability for decisions made with AI assistance and ensure robust governance, oversight and risk management.

Murmu underlined the importance of transparency in AI-driven decisions, stating that customers should be informed when automated systems are being used and must have access to human review when decisions significantly affect them.

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INFORMATION REGARDING 42nd ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING
TO BE HELD THROUGH VIDEO CONFERENCE /
OTHER AUDIO-VISUAL MEANS AND NOTICE OF RECORD DATE

Notice is hereby given that the 42nd Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of the Company will be held on Friday, the 18th September 2026 at 4:00 P.M IST through Video Conferencing (VC) / Other Audio Visual Means (OAVM) facility, in accordance with General Circulars dated 22nd September 2025, read together with circulars dated 8th April 2020, 13th April 2020, 5th May 2020, 13th January 2021, 14th December 2021, 5th May 2022, 28th December 2022 and 19th September 2024 issued by Ministry of Corporate Affairs (collectively referred to as "MCA Circulars") and Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI") Circular dated 3rd October 2024 without the physical presence of the Members at the common venue.

Dispatch of Annual Report
The Notice of the AGM and the Annual Report for the year 2025-26 including the financial statements for the year ended 31st March 2026 will be sent only by email to all those Members, whose email addresses are registered with the Company or with their respective Depository Participants ("Depository"). The Notice of the AGM and the Annual Report will also be available on the Company's website www.pitti.in, websites of the Stock Exchanges, i.e., BSE Limited (at www.bseindia.com) and National Stock Exchange of India Limited (at www.nseindia.com).

Manner of registering / updating E-mail Address:
Members holding shares in electronic form and who have not updated their email or KYC details are requested to register / update the details in their demat account as per the process advised by their Depository. Members holding shares in physical mode and who have not updated their email address or KYC details are requested to register / update the details in the prescribed Form ISR-1 with the Registrar and Share Transfer Agent (RTA) of the Company viz., MUFG Intime India Private Limited, (Formerly Link Intime India Private Limited) ("MUFG"), C-110, Embassy 247, L.B.S. Marg, Vikhroli (West), Mumbai – 400 083 or email at investor_helpdesk @in.mnps.mufg.com.

The format of Form ISR-1 is available on the Company's website at www.pitti.in and on the website of the RTA at <https://web.in.mnps.mufg.com/KYC-c-downloads.html>

Participation in AGM through VCO/AVM
In accordance with the MCA Circulars and the SEBI Circulars, Members can join and participate in the AGM through VC / OAVM facility only. The instructions for joining the AGM and the manner of participation in the remote electronic voting or casting vote through the e-voting system during the AGM are provided in the Notice of the AGM. Members participating through the VCO/AVM facility shall be counted for the purpose of reckoning the quorum under Section 103 of the Companies Act, 2013.

Manner of casting vote(s) on Resolutions placed before the AGM through e-voting
Pursuant to the provisions of Section 108 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014 and Regulation 44 of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 the Company is providing e-voting facility to its members to exercise their votes electronically for transacting the Items of business enumerated in Notice of the 42nd AGM through MUFG Intime India Private Limited. The remote e-voting period commences on Tuesday, 15th September 2026 (9:00 a.m. IST) and ends on Thursday, 17th September 2026 (5:00 p.m. IST). During this period, Members holding shares either in physical form or in dematerialized form, as on Friday, 11th September 2026 i.e. cut-off date, may cast their vote electronically. The e-voting module shall be disabled by MUFG for voting thereafter. Those Members, who will be present in the AGM through VC / OAVM facility and have not cast their vote on the resolutions through remote e-voting and are otherwise not barred from doing so, shall be eligible to vote through e-voting system during the AGM.

Dividend and Record date
The final dividend, if approved by the Members will be paid within 30 days from the conclusion of the AGM, to the Members whose names appear on the Company's Register of Members as on Friday, 11th September 2026 and in respect of the shares held in dematerialised mode, to the Members whose names are furnished by National Securities Depository Limited and Central Depository Services (India) Limited as beneficial owners as on that date.

Tax on dividend
Pursuant to Income Tax Act, 2025 ("the IT Act"), dividend income is taxable in the hands of the members and the Company is required to deduct tax at source ("TDS") from dividend paid to the members at the prescribed rates in the IT Act. Further details on TDS on dividend are provided on the Company's website at <http://www.pitti.in/investor-desk/investors-si-f-id.php> and on the website of the RTA at <https://web.in.mnps.mufg.com/client-downloads.html>

By Order of the Board
For Pitti Engineering Limited
Sd/-
Mary Monica Braganza
Company Secretary & Chief Compliance Officer
FCS: 5532

Place: Hyderabad
Date : 19th August 2026

INDIAN INSTITUTE OF BANKING & FINANCE

CIN : U91110MH1928GA001391
Kohinoor City, Commercial II Tower - 1, 2nd Floor, Kirod Road,
Kurla (West) Mumbai 400070
Tel: +91-8069260700 Email: admin@iibf.org.in

NOTICE is hereby given that the 99th Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of the Institute will be held on Thursday, 10th September, 2026 at 4:30 PM IST through Two-Way Video Conferencing ("VC") / Other Audio-Visual Mode ("OAVM") ONLY to transact the Business, as set out in the Notice for the 99th AGM. The AGM will be held through VC/OAVM without the physical presence of the members at a common venue in compliance with the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 and Rules framed thereunder read with Circulars dated April 8th, 2020, April 13th, 2020, December 31st, 2020, January 12th, 2021, May 5th, 2022, December 28th, 2022 and September 25th, 2023, September 19th, 2024 and September 22nd, 2025 respectively issued by Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA Circulars"). The registered office of the Institute shall be deemed to be the venue for the meeting.

In compliance with the aforesaid circulars, the Annual Report of the Company for 2025-26 along with the Notice of the AGM has been dispatched by e-mail to all the members whose e-mail addresses are available and registered with the Institute on 18th August, 2026. The requirement for sending the physical copy of the 99th AGM Notice and Annual Report to members has been dispensed vide MCA Circulars. Accordingly, the facility for appointment of proxies by the Members will not be available for the AGM. A copy of the Notice of the AGM along with the Annual Report is available on the website of the Institute at <https://www.iibf.org.in/annualreport> and website of NSDL at <https://www.evoting.nsdl.com>

Remote E-Voting and E-Voting at the AGM
In compliance with Section 108 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with Rule 20 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014, Members are provided with the facility to cast their votes on all resolutions set forth in the Notice of the AGM using electronic voting system ("remote e-voting"), provided by National Securities Depository Limited (NSDL) and the business may be transacted through such voting. The details for the e-voting pursuant to the Act and the Rules are hereunder:

- The Ordinary Business and Special Business as set out in the AGM may be transacted through voting by electronic means. The Notice for AGM along with e-voting instructions is available along with the Annual Report on the website of the Institute at <https://www.iibf.org.in/annualreport> and website of NSDL <https://www.evoting.nsdl.com>.
- Institutional members are required to send a scanned copy (PDF/JPG Format) of its Board or Governing Body Resolution/Authorization etc., authorizing its representative to attend the AGM through VC / OAVM on its behalf and to vote through remote e-voting. The said Resolution/Authorization shall be sent to the Scrutinizer by email through its registered email address to scrutiniser@csdskamat.com with a copy marked to evoting@nsdl.com.
- The remote e-voting period commences on Sunday, 6th September, 2026 (9:00 AM IST) and ends on Wednesday, 9th September, 2026 (5:00 PM IST) (both days inclusive). During this period, the Members may cast their vote electronically. The e-voting module shall be disabled by NSDL thereafter and remote e-voting will not be permitted beyond the prescribed time.
- The cut-off date for determining the eligibility status of members for voting through remote e-voting and at the AGM is 3rd September, 2026.
- Further, in pursuance to the Articles of Association, only Institutional Members, Associate Members and Fellow Members will be authorized to vote through e-voting at the AGM. Associate and Fellow Members shall be entitled to one vote per person and Institutional Members shall be entitled to one vote for every Rs. 1,000/- in contribution towards their Annual Subscription Fees as on the cut-off date. Any person, who is an Institutional, Associate or Fellow Member of the Institute as on the cut-off date is eligible to cast vote on all the resolutions set forth in the Notice of AGM using remote e-voting or voting at the AGM (only through E-voting system). Other members may please treat this Notice for information purpose only.
- The facility for voting through electronic voting system shall also be made available at the AGM and Members who have not already cast their vote by remote e-voting shall be able to exercise their right at the AGM. The Members who have cast their vote by remote e-voting prior to the AGM may also attend the AGM but shall not be allowed to cast their vote again at the AGM.
- A person who has become a member of the Institute after the dispatch of notice of AGM and having right to vote as of cut-off date, may obtain the login ID and password by sending a request at evoting@nsdl.com. However, if the person is already registered with NSDL for remote e-voting then the existing user ID and password can be used for casting vote.
- Those members whose email address are not registered with the Institute may register their email address with Institute by sending email to Dr. Dharmvir Marchingo, Deputy Director on dd.mss@iibf.org.in.
- For details relating to remote e-voting and E-Voting at AGM, please refer to the Notice of the AGM. In case of any queries relating to voting by electronic means, please refer to the Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) and e-voting user manual for Members available at the Downloads section of www.evoting.nsdl.com or contact at Mr. Sanjeev Yadav, Senior Manager, NSDL, 4th Floor, 'A' Wing, Trade World, Kamala Mills Compound, Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Panel, Mumbai 400013. Email: evoting@nsdl.com / Tel: 022-48867000. Members may also write to Mr. Dharmvir Marchingo, Deputy Director on dd.mss@iibf.org.in.

The Notes to the AGM Notice contain the detailed instructions for manner of attendance and e-voting at the AGM for all Voting and Non-voting members. Members are requested to refer to the same for attending the AGM.

For Indian Institute of Banking & Finance

Deepak Kumar Lalla
Chief Executive Officer
DIN: 09648283

Place: Mumbai
Date: 19.08.2026

QUICKLY.

Charles Schwab opens GCC, to recruit 500 in yr 1

Hyderabad: Financial services firm, Charles Schwab of the US has opened Schwab India, a capability centre here to support its US business. It represents a long-term investment in Charles Schwab's global growth and its expanding presence in India's tech ecosystem. It will operate from a 3.45 lakh sq ft facility. Over 500 persons will be recruited in year one, and around 2,000 by the end of 2027. **OUR BUREAU**

Govt to offer CGDs more gas as incentive to expand

New Delhi: The government will offer city gas distributors (CGDs) an additional 200 standard cu m of lower-priced domestic natural gas for every new billed household piped-gas connection. The incentive, effective from September 1, will apply to incremental domestic piped cooking gas or piped natural gas connections above a threshold set for each geographical area. **PII**

SC advises meaningful continuity in NTA reforms, not committee-hopping

NEET REFORMS. Centre told to first file affidavit on action taken on recommendations by Radhakrishnan panel

Krishnadas Rajagopal
New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday emphasised the need for institutionalising reforms within the National Testing Agency (NTA) while indicating that the government must not hop from one committee to the next in search of solutions.

The NTA has been under the Supreme Court scanner since the NEET-UG 2026 paper leaks.

The Union government has constituted the “task force” chaired by Infosys co-founder Nandan Nilekani to usher in technological reforms, which would make the conduct of public exams under the NTA leak-proof.

But a Bench headed by Justice PS Narasimha persisted to question the Union government on what it has done so far to implement the recommendations of an

earlier committee headed by former ISRO chairman K Radhakrishnan to improve the NTA's exam processes.

“It should not be that a committee gives recommendations, then a new committee is formed which removes the old one, lock, stock and barrel,” Justice Narasimha said.

The court said the reforms in NTA should focus on building an “institutional memory”.

The court said there ought to be meaningful continuity in resolving systemic problems within the NTA.

The reforms must be vibrant, institutionalised and carried on within NTA by successive officers. They should not be a knee-jerk reaction after a catastrophe, Justice Narasimha said. The Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) has been conducting public exams without a hitch, he said.

The 2026 NEET-UG ques-



DREAMS SHATTERED. The NEET-UG 2026 paper leaks led to the exam's cancellation, affecting 23 lakh aspirants

tion paper leaks resulted in the cancellation of the exams, leaving over 23 lakh medical aspirants stranded. A CBI investigation was ordered, and arrests made. However, the NEET-UG leaks led to nationwide protests and police crackdown on students, ultimately leading to the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

“Life changes with every exam. The system changes with every exam. There are

new technological challenges. How are you facing them? Have you developed the necessary infrastructure? Have you the software systems required in place? What about cyber security and storage?” Justice Narasimha asked Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Union government and the NTA.

‘FILE AFFIDAVIT’

The court referred to an August 4 affidavit filed by the

Five-fold increase in notebook imports hits domestic industry

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

The domestic notebook industry has called for a level playing field to counter the severe competition from imports. It says notebook imports have increased five-fold in the first six months of the calendar year, putting pressure on domestic players.

The value of imports rose to ₹22.36 crore during the January-June 2026 period, from ₹3.65 crore, marking an increase of over five times, according to the data from the Ministry of Commerce.

Industry players said that

the increase in imports was driven by the hike in domestic notebook prices. The shift to a nil GST rate on notebooks under GST 2.0 has created an unintended cost burden for domestic manufacturers. Since they can no longer claim input tax credit under Section 17(2) of the CGST Act, 2017, taxes paid on inputs are now being embedded in the cost of production.

“Indian notebook manufacturers are not asking for protection from competition; they are asking for a fair and level playing field. The current tax structure has created an uneven situation, where domestic manufactur-



IMPORT SHIELD. The domestic industry has called for urgent policy intervention, including the imposition of a safeguard duty

ers bear the burden of embedded input taxes, while imported notebooks can

enter the Indian market with a significantly lower tax burden,” said Abhinav Jain,

Member, All India Notebook Manufacturers Association (AINMA).

POLICY INTERVENTIONS

To address this challenge, the domestic industry has called for urgent policy interventions, including the imposition of a safeguard duty to support the Indian notebook manufacturing ecosystem.

Imported notebooks, particularly from Asean countries, enjoy a significantly different tax treatment. Under the Asean Free Trade Agreement, eligible notebook imports attract zero Basic Customs Duty (BCD), while the nil GST rate means

that there is no IGST payable on imports.

“This effectively gives overseas suppliers a much lower landed cost and enables them to compete with Indian manufacturers at a significant price advantage,” a domestic notebook maker said.

The industry has urged the government to immediately consider a safeguard or compensatory import duty of 9-10 per cent on notebook imports under ‘exercise books’.

This duty will help neutralise the estimated input tax disadvantage faced by domestic manufacturers and restore a more competitive environment.

Gujarat CM meets Micron, Google and Perplexity CEOs, pitches State as AI hub

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel on Wednesday deepened the State's engagement with global technology companies by meeting senior leaders from Micron, Google and Perplexity AI during the third day of his US visit, ahead of the Vibrant Gujarat Summit 2027.

Patel's meetings with Micron Chairman and CEO Sanjay Mehrotra, Google Vice-President Chandu Thota and Perplexity CEO Aravind Srinivas focused on semiconductors, artificial intelligence, data infrastructure, skilling and potential investments in Gujarat.

POTENTIAL TO PARTNER

At Micron, Mehrotra thanked Patel for the State government's swift approval of 20 acres for the company's Sanand facility. The Micron



Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel

chief also appreciated the State's efforts to facilitate the early commencement of commercial production at the semiconductor unit, according to a State government release.

At Google, the delegation discussed potential collaboration across several areas, with Thota expressing interest in working with the State on youth skilling, artificial intelligence (AI) training for teachers and students, and the use of AI in agriculture.

Google and the Gujarat government also discussed data security and the use of Google Workspace Sovereign AI, indicating a broader focus on building AI capabilities while addressing data governance requirements.

DATA CENTRES

In a separate one-on-one meeting, Patel and Perplexity CEO Srinivas discussed bringing the AI search company's engineering and research-and-development operations to Gujarat.

The talks also explored the possibility of establishing a Perplexity data centre in Gujarat or developing a hybrid arrangement involving developers and Perplexity, the release said.

Patel also met members of The Indus Entrepreneurs (TIE) of Silicon Valley, with the discussions covering collaboration in healthcare, training and youth skilling through AI tools.

Micron plant gets Gujarat's first approval for 12-hour shifts

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

The Gujarat government has approved 12-hour work shifts at Micron Semiconductor Technology India Pvt Ltd's Sanand facility, marking the first such approval for any factory in the State while retaining the statutory limit of 48 working hours per week.

The approval has been granted under the Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions (OSH) Code, 2020, which came into force across India on November 21, 2020. The Code permits State governments to grant exemptions to factories from certain provisions, subject to prescribed safeguards.

Workers can opt for the extended shifts only with written consent, while the remaining days will be treated as paid leave, accord-

ing to an official release on Wednesday.

“Gujarat has exercised this provision, keeping in view the larger public interest, economic growth and employment generation in the State,” said Labour, Skill Development and Employment Minister Kunvarji Bavaliya in the release.

The approval is aimed at accommodating the operational requirements of semiconductor manufacturing, where production processes run continuously in highly controlled clean room environments. Chip assembly and testing involve sophisticated automated equipment that operate around the clock, making uninterrupted production important for equipment utilisation, efficiency and product quality.

Industry experts cited by the State government said 12-hour shifts are a globally accepted operating model in semicon manufacturing.

Technology, brand building critical growth engines for retail

Our Bureau
Chennai

As technological changes create a paradigm shift in consumer shopping behavior, Chennai's prominent retailers believe that making the most of these trends will be key to maximising the potential of these businesses while continuing to carry forward their decades-old legacy.

The industry leaders and executives were speaking at the Chennai Retail Summit 2026 here on Wednesday.

Bijou Kurien, Chairman - Retailers Association of India (RAI), said, “We need to evolve from viewing technology as a separate retail function, to being part of the core infrastructure on which businesses run. Technology has become critical whether it is in terms of payments, inventory management, or e-

commerce. Customers in the past would come to the store to look at products, choose, buy and leave. Now they will walk into a store with a model name and stand and use the Wi-Fi of the store to compare the price on Amazon or Flipkart, and then decide whether they should buy in the store, or whether they should buy online. They are making up their mind in several ways outside of the store before they enter the store.”

BRAND BUILDING

The event saw the presence of Nalli Chinnasami Chetty, the founder of Nalli Silk Sarees. He cited the example of his own venture that scaled from a small single room store to a multi-outlet saree-retail chain in Chennai.

The 87-year-old founder mentioned how later generations of a family business can

build on the foundation to achieve much larger success.

Sunil Sanklecha, founder of Gourmet retail chain Nuts and Spices said that brand building, cultural values and succession planning are essential for retailers to sustain growth.

CK Kumaravel, Founder of Naturals Salon, said that given the increasing number of options that are available across products and services, it is important for brands not to depend only on customer loyalty but to build on that trust and constantly innovate to give them the best possible offering.

“It is no longer about customers being loyal to the brands, brands now have to be loyal to the customers,” he said.

Kumar Rajagopalan, CEO of RAI, said that traditional Tamil Nadu-based retailers were pioneers in the industry.

India to deepen ties with Taliban govt, but formal recognition still on hold

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

India will officially recognise the Taliban government in Afghanistan “in due time” after greater clarity on security and social issues, but until then it will continue to deepen diplomatic and economic engagement with Kabul, given Afghanistan's strategic importance to the country, sources said.

“New Delhi is keen to build strong economic and diplomatic ties with Kabul, given India's longstanding relationship with Afghanistan as well as its strategic interests, particularly in the context of Afghanistan's growing differences with Pakistan and China's expanding influence in the region. While formal recognition of the Taliban regime is expected in due time, certain issues need to be addressed first, including adequate security assurances and greater clarity on inclusivity and humanitarian and social concerns,” a source tracking the matter told *businessline*.

There are historic ties between the people of Afghanistan and the people of India and particularly over the last year, these relations have gained considerable momentum through diplomatic exchanges, humanitarian assistance and development co-operation programs, Minister of External Affairs Spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said at a briefing this week.

“Afghanistan's growing differences with Pakistan are one of the primary factors driving New Delhi to deepen its engagement with Kabul,” the source said. India's need to counter China's expanding influence in the region is another reason.

There have already been several high-profile Afghan ministerial visits to India,



starting with Foreign Minister Amir Khan Muttaqi, who met External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar in October 2025.

TRADE TIES

The Afghan Minister of Industry and Commerce Nooruddin Azizi visited next, leading a strong Afghan business delegation to New Delhi focusing on expanding bilateral trade and improving transit and connectivity. He was followed by Afghan Minister of Public Health Noor Jalal Jalali.

Last month, Afghan Minister for Agriculture Mawlawi Ataullah Omari visited the country and explored new avenues for collaboration in agriculture, irrigation, livestock, agricultural research, education, capacity building and agri-trade, according to the MEA.

“Details of the meetings between the Indian and Afghan Ministers were officially shared by the government despite the fact that the Taliban regime is not officially recognised by India,” another source noted.

Before India officially recognises the Taliban regime, it would first want a firm assurance that Afghan territory will not be used for anti-India terrorist activities or by groups inimical to India, the source said. There is also considerable international criticism of the Taliban's record on human rights, women's rights and social inclusivity, which remains another factor that India would need to take into account before extending formal recognition.

Amit Shah to chair Southern Zonal Council meeting today

Our Bureau
Chennai

Union Home Minister Amit Shah will chair the 31st meeting of the Southern Zonal Council (SZC) in Mamallapuram, near Chennai, on Thursday.

The Council provides a forum for resolving issues between the Centre and the member States and Union Territories.

The Southern Zonal Council comprises Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Telangana, and the Union Territories of Puducherry, the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, and Lakshadweep.

Shah is the Chairman of the Southern Zonal Council, and Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay is the Vice-Chairman. The Chief Ministers of the member States

serve as Vice-Chairman of the Council by rotation. The meeting will be attended by the Chief Ministers/Lt Governors/Administrators of the southern region, along with two senior Ministers from each State.

The Chief Secretaries/Advisors and other senior officers of the State governments, as well as senior officers of the Central government, will also participate in the meeting.

STANDING COMMITTEE

The Zonal Council has constituted a standing committee at the level of Chief Secretaries.

Issues proposed by the States are submitted for discussion before this committee, and after deliberation there, the remaining issues are placed before the Zonal Council meeting for consideration, the statement said.

US envoy Sergio Gor signals Kashmir travel advisory review, economic ties in focus

Gulzar Bhat
Srinagar

US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor on Wednesday signalled that Washington could reconsider its travel advisory for Jammu and Kashmir, while talks with Chief Minister Omar Abdullah focused on expanding economic cooperation and creating opportunities for businesses in India and the US.

Gor made the comments after meeting Abdullah in Srinagar during a two-day visit to Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh.

He stopped short of announcing any immediate change to the advisory, saying the US periodically reassesses its travel warnings and would examine whether the existing warning for



Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah with US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor in Srinagar **ANI**

Jammu and Kashmir should be downgraded.

“The government has taken incredible steps to make this area safer. So, we will look at whether the travel warning imposed by the US should be downgraded,” Gor said.

“This is a beautiful area, I think a lot of Americans would enjoy coming here and seeing the beauty and oppor-

tunity that exists here,” he said. In a post on X, Gor said, “We discussed ways to deepen economic collaboration and create opportunities that would mutually benefit both of our nations.”

The meeting comes as Jammu and Kashmir seeks to expand investment and strengthen its links with international markets, with tourism, handicrafts, horti-

culture and other sectors forming important parts of the local economy.

Political observers said the US advisory could have wider significance beyond American visitors. “Travel warnings issued by major Western governments can influence perceptions among international tourists and businesses,” said Shahnawaz Hussain, a political analyst.

‘NO EXTERNAL ROLE’

Chief Minister Abdullah said, “Washington will not resolve our issues. Our issues have to be resolved by our Central government.”

He said that it would be inappropriate for him to complain about his country to the ambassador of another nation. “It has not been my habit, and I won't do it,” he said.

Tamil Nadu raises milk procurement price to ₹41/litre

Our Bureau
Chennai

The Tamil Nadu government announced a ₹3 increase in milk procurement price to ₹41 per litre.

Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay announced this in the Assembly on Wednesday.

In Tamil Nadu, 3.4 million litres of milk are procured daily from 3.16 million producers through 8,800 co-operatives, while 3.1 million litres are sold to consumers daily through Aavin.

The government has decided to increase the milk procurement price through co-operatives by ₹1 per litre and raise the government incentive from ₹3 to ₹5 per litre, taking the total procurement price from ₹38 to ₹41 per litre.

This will benefit over 3,16,000 milk producers who

The move will cost the State an additional ₹30 cr per month

supply to primary milk producers' cooperatives.

The move will cost the State government an additional ₹30 crore per month and ₹360 crore per year, he said.

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thehindu businessline .	

QUICKLY.

**Campbell Wilson to join
Air New Zealand board**



New Delhi: Outgoing Air India Chief Executive Officer and Managing Director Campbell Wilson has been appointed as Director on the board of Air New Zealand, subject to shareholder approval, the airline announced. Wilson has more than three decades of experience in aviation, and has previously held multiple senior executive positions across the industry. He had earlier held several senior executive roles at Singapore Airlines, including that of Senior Vice-President, Sales and Marketing. Wilson was also the founding Chief Executive Officer of Scoot, Singapore Airlines' low-cost carrier. Further, Wilson has served as a member of the Board of Directors of the International Air Transport Association. **our BUREAU**

**Murf AI aims to compete
big in voice arena**

A Bengaluru-based start-up has entered the crowded race to build artificial voices that sound human, with an AI model that garners high scores versus systems from OpenAI and ElevenLabs Inc. Murf AI's text-to-speech Falcon 2, publicly available from August 20, ranked higher than some platforms from better-funded players such as OpenAI's Realtime API in benchmarks on Artificial Analysis, the independent platform that tracks AI performance. Falcon 2 is priced at \$0.01 per generated minute, a fifth of the price of larger competitors such as ElevenLabs.

Air India Express introduces substance use self-declaration

AVERTING DANGER. Move aimed at early intervention, strengthening safety reporting

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

Tata Group-promoted Air India Express has introduced a voluntary self-declaration process for employees to report the use, misuse, dependence on or abuse of psychoactive substances, sources told *businessline*. The move, said sources, is part of a structured and confidential safety reporting mechanism.

According to sources, the initiative has been introduced in accordance with the Directorate General of Civil Aviation's (DGCA) civil aviation requirements (CAR).

The current CAR encourages crews to voluntarily declare any psychoactive substance use that may affect their fitness for duty and ability to safely perform assigned responsibilities.

Accordingly, the airline has circulated a safety circular titled 'Safety Circular 04 of 2026 - Self Declaration for



SAFE FLIGHT. Employees can make a voluntary declaration through the airline's safety reporting platform or through designated e-mail addresses **REUTERS**

Use of Psychoactive Substances' among employees.

Under the process, employees can make a voluntary declaration through the airline's safety reporting platform, or through designated e-mail addresses.

The circular said that self-declarations will be handled with strict confidentiality and shared only on a need-to-know basis with authorised personnel identified in

the circular. According to sources, the objective of the initiative is to promote safety, employee well-being, early intervention and recovery through a confidential and structured reporting process.

The initiative is not a reaction to any specific incident, and does not indicate any specific issue within the airline, said sources.

Rather, they pointed out

that it is a measure being positioned as a proactive safety and well-being initiative, aimed at strengthening the reporting culture and safety governance within the airline. Meanwhile, industry insiders say other airlines may follow suit.

DRUG SCANDAL

At present, the aviation industry has been rocked by a drug scandal after the pilot-in-command of the August 4 Air India Phuket-Delhi flight returned a non-negative preliminary screening result in a test for psychoactive substances. As of now, the results of the secondary test have not been officially confirmed.

The pilot was tested after he commanded the Air India flight operated on an Airbus A320neo registered VT-EXO. Notably, the aircraft suffered a sudden loss of altitude of around 300 feet during cruise before stabilising and landing safely in Delhi.

NCLT set to hear claims of lessors against SpiceJet

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) will hear afresh seven insolvency petitions filed by aircraft lessors against SpiceJet. The development comes after one of the original litigants, Aviator ML, withdrew its petition following a settlement with the airline.

The tribunal had prepared a judgment covering eight petitions against SpiceJet.

However, following the withdrawal of the Aviator ML petition, the judgment could not be delivered, and the remaining seven matters will now be heard afresh by a new Bench.

'A POSITIVE STEP'

On its part, SpiceJet welcomed the development, describing the order as a positive step towards resolving the outstanding matters.

"We view the order as a positive step towards resolv-



ing the outstanding matters and remain committed to working closely and constructively with our partners to find mutually acceptable solutions," said a SpiceJet spokesperson.

The airline said it remained focused on rebuilding its operations and restoring its fleet.

"SpiceJet has been through a challenging period and is focused on rebuilding the airline, strengthening its operations and restoring its fleet," said the spokesperson.

UAE imposes financial embargo on Iran after missile threat

Reuters
Dubai

The United Arab Emirates' decision to suspend all financial and economic transactions with Iran until further notice, citing a military escalation by Tehran with a missile threat, has refocused the spotlight on fraught ties between the major Gulf Arab oil producer and Iran.

The UAE, a close US ally and regional power, was the Gulf state most heavily hit by Tehran during the early stages of the West Asia war.

However, the last reported attack on UAE soil was the May 4 strike on Fujairah port, a key oil export hub. The move by the UAE to sever commercial ties came after its Defence Ministry said that it had detected two ballistic missiles launched from Iran, an incident that marked the first time in months that residents received telephone alerts warning of possible threats.

In a statement, the Ministry said the missiles targeted maritime traffic based on its assessments. Both missiles fell into the sea, it said. The UAE also sent a phone alert on Tuesday to residents stating that the situation was safe and people should resume normal activities after the earlier warning.

Iran's Foreign Ministry rejected the statement by the UAE that its missiles targeted maritime traffic, describing it as "baseless".

UAE official Afra Al Hameli, Director of the Strategic Communications Department at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, said the UAE was committed to dialogue and cooperation to advance peace, stability and prosperity in the region.

Pixel's China exit to bring fresh opportunities to Indian manufacturers

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

With reports around Google's likely exit from China for Pixel smartphone production, India is likely to see new smartphone export opportunities.

While Google declined to confirm media reports of its move from China to other countries like India and Vietnam, analysts remain excited about the development's prospects for India.

"Any brand that comes to India for manufacturing af-

firms that Indian manufacturing is as world class as any other country. So, it gives confidence to investors, local manufacturers, people trying to set up a supply chain ecosystem in India. It may not translate into volumes, but it's a positive sentiment to the entire industry," said Prachir Singh, Senior Analyst at Counterpoint Research, flagging setting up of supply chain ecosystem.

While industry trackers stressed that volume of production and exports may not see a huge bump up with Google Pixel, the move can

help in putting India at the centre of Google's future hardware expansion plans in the AI age, and can replicate what Apple did to India's smartphone manufacturing ecosystem.

MORE ATTRACTIVE

"Google already makes it phones here through two partners. Having more of the Google Pixel current and future models made here will give an overall boost to the attractiveness of India's electronics manufacturing ecosystem. In terms of volume, Google Pixel's

Pixel was the fastest-growing brand in the premium segment in India in Q2

phones are not too sizable," said Sasikumar Gendham, President, ELCINA (Electronic Industries Association of India), adding that partners also have sufficient capacity here in India.

Google's smartphones are assembled and manufactured in India at two main locations — Foxconn's facil-

ity in Tamil Nadu and Dixon Technologies' subsidiary Padget Electronics in Noida.

Another smartphones industry tracker pointed out that India itself is not yet a big Pixel market, and domestic market reach first needs to improve for the brand. The distribution to all the corners of India still needs to be fixed for Pixel, he added.

FAST GROWTH

However, Pixel was the fastest growing brand in the premium segment in India in Q2, which has increased

Google's focus on the Indian market, pointed out Singh. Further, Apple has seen this trajectory with India now exporting more iPhones than any other country to the US.

"On top of that, India has also introduced the Mobile Phone Manufacturing Scheme, which people are saying is PLI 2.0. That is also prompting OEMs to expand their manufacturing in India. In the coming years, Pixel will start exporting in a decent quantity from India to other countries," he said.

With Inputs from Sindhu Hariharan

Indian women set to inherit ₹73 lakh cr, but only 23% have wealth transfer plans: Barclays report

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

Women in India are expected to inherit at least ₹73 lakh crore in intergenerational wealth over the next decade, yet only 23 per cent of those who have inherited wealth have fully structured wealth transfer plans in place, according to a report released by Barclays Private Bank.

The report, *The Ownership Shift*, surveyed 22 women leaders across entrepreneurship, fund management, investing and family wealth stewardship. It found that while awareness of wealth is increasing, preparedness remains uneven.

Around 54 per cent of respondents said their wealth transfer plans are still under development, while another 23 per cent acknowledged



being aware of their holdings but are yet to formulate a concrete plan.

Despite the planning gap, the report highlights a growing level of engagement among women in investment management. A notable 76 per cent of respondents are actively involved in managing investments, with 38 per cent directly evaluating and monitoring individual investment opportunities.

Wealth creation emerged as the primary investment objective for 86 per cent of respondents, challenging the long-held assumption that women investors tend to be more conservative.

INVESTMENT PLANS

Looking ahead to the next three to five years, 40 per cent said they intend to prioritise private equity, venture capital and direct start-up investments for fresh capital allocation. This was significantly higher than the preference for public markets, fixed income and real assets, each of which attracted 20 per cent of respondents.

On investment risk, 85 per cent of respondents described their approach as balanced, carefully weighing risk against potential returns. The report character-

ises this stance as risk intelligent, rather than risk averse.

The findings are reinforced by broader global research cited in the report, which showed that female CEOs delivered revenue growth of 10 per cent in 2024, compared with 8 per cent for companies led by male CEOs. The report also points to the rising influence of women in India's financial and corporate landscape. Women fund managers, either solely managing or co-managing funds, oversaw ₹13.45 lakh crore, or 20 per cent of the mutual fund industry's total assets under management (AUM) as of January 2025. This marks a sharp increase from ₹6.66 lakh crore a year earlier.

MORE ENTREPRENEURS

Entrepreneurship is also seeing greater female participa-

tion. As of December 2024, 75,935 DPIIT-recognised start-ups had at least one woman director.

Meanwhile, women occupied 21 per cent of board seats in NSE-listed companies as of February 2026, up significantly from just 5 per cent in March 2014.

Balancing time and attention emerged as the biggest challenge for respondents, cited by 50 per cent of those surveyed. Finding trusted advice ranked second at 30 per cent.

A substantial 71 per cent said improving investment knowledge and confidence would be the single most important enhancement to their financial lives. Trust and transparency also featured prominently in advisor relationships, with 85 per cent saying these were the qualities they valued most.

‘Only 1 in 15 Indians have active smartphone protection plans’

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

Despite 84 per cent of Indian smartphone owners being aware of device protection plans, fewer than one in 15 have active coverage, a disconnect that a new industry study says is costing consumers dearly as device prices climb and repair bills mount.

InsurTech platform OneAssist, in partnership with Hansa Research, on Wednesday released findings from a 1,260-respondent nationwide study, titled *The Great Indian Smartphone Protection Crisis*, which reveals that while 72 per cent of consumers have suffered accidental damage and 82 per cent have dropped their phones at least once, current active protection plan adoption stands at just 6-8 per

cent. The study pegs the gap between lifetime awareness and active coverage as the central crisis in a market of over 650 million smartphone users.

Average device prices in India have risen 40-50 per cent in recent years, and the replacement cycle has stretched to approximately 40 months, up from two years a decade ago.

CRACKED SCREENS

Cracked screens account for the most common damage outcome, reported by 70 per cent of affected users. Of all damage incidents, 36 per cent occurs because a phone slips from a pocket or bag, making ordinary commutes the single biggest risk factor, outpacing water exposure (15 per cent), walking or running (13 per cent) and travel (12 per cent).

The emotional toll is also

documented. The study found 35 per cent of respondents panicked immediately after dropping their phone; 24 per cent had a conflict with someone over the incident and 15 per cent cancelled plans as a result.

Women recorded a sharper panic response at 43 per cent, versus 33 per cent for men, and were also more prone to damage — 79 per cent reported accidental damage, compared to 71 per cent of men.

SUPPLY SIDE

On the supply side, the study identifies three structural barriers to adoption: cost concerns, cited by 44 per cent of non-adopters; limited understanding of plan benefits; and distrust of the claims process, with four in 10 consumers doubting whether claims would be honoured fairly.

Isthmus 44 sees ‘untapped’ opportunity in India’s ultra-premium whisky market

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

India, the world's largest whisky-consuming market, is seeing growing interest in independent bottlers and rare single-cask Scotch, with Isthmus 44 betting the category is at the start of a growth curve similar to markets such as Taiwan.

Isthmus 44, operated under Tartan Paisley Bev Private Ltd, is one of India's first independent bottlers and curatorial houses for single-cask Scotch whisky.

"We don't make whisky; we choose it. Rather than distilling or blending, we select individual casks directly from distilleries and warehouses in Scotland and bottle each one as a finite, numbered release we call a Chapter. No two casks are ever identical, so no Chapter

is ever repeated," explained Sachin Uppal, Founder of Isthmus 44, an independent bottler.

Uppal highlighted that independent bottling is a new idea for most Indian consumers.

He noted that enquiries for Chapter One had crossed its full out-turn of 300-odd bottles, driven by organic interest.

SCOTCH SPEND

"It mirrors what happened in markets like Taiwan, where a culture of single malt appreciation was built in large part by local independent bottlers rather than big brands, and where per-capita Scotch spend is now among the highest in the world. We think India is at the very start of that same curve," he noted.

Despite India's crowded whisky market, the ultra-



Sachin Uppal, Founder, Isthmus 44

Isthmus 44 will never be volume-driven. "Scaling by making more of the same cask isn't possible, and manufacturing scarcity to fake growth isn't something we're interested in. We want to expand to more States and cities over the next couple of years, but that growth will always be provenance-driven, not volume-driven," Uppal shared.

INVESTOR INTEREST

Isthmus 44 has no in-house bottling or cask facilities. Bottling happens in Scotland because, according to SWA regulation, single malt Scotch has to be bottled at origin to legally carry the name.

The company has raised a seed round from a small group of investors and is in discussions for a larger follow-on round to fund expansion.

premium, curated segment remains largely untapped. Currently, the company has private clients around the world.

EXPANSION PLANS

Domestically, the company has a presence in Gurugram, Haryana. It is looking to expand into Chandigarh, Bengaluru, Mumbai and Pune.

Moreover, he added that

QR coding for medicines needs to take next leap in standardisation of format: GS1 CEO

PT Jyothi Datta
Mumbai

A QR code gives consumers information on a product but that in isolation is not enough, says S Swaminathan, CEO with supply-chain standards organisation GS1 India. The entire healthcare supply chain needs to be secure and connected with data presented in a uniform manner to be able to weed out possible counterfeits in the supply chain.

The Centre recently expanded its initiative mandating QR codes for medicinal products, including cancer drugs, narcotics, psychotropic drugs and vaccines, by July 1, 2027, and antimicrobials by July 1, 2028.

DATA ELEMENTS

The QR code provides consumers nine data elements



S Swaminathan, Chief Executive Officer, GS1 India

for each drug product — the unique product identification code, proper and generic name of the drug, brand name, name and address of the manufacturer, batch number, date of manufacture, date of expiry, manufacturing licence number and details of excipients, a note from the Health Ministry explained.

"The availability of these details through digital authentication tools will facilitate seamless verification and tracking of medicines across the supply chain," it added.

While QR codes give consumers product information as mandated by the Centre, Swaminathan pointed out that the initiative needs to leap to the next level in terms of standardisation of the format in which information is presented, so that it could be uniformly read across the supply chain, including warehouses, distributors, stockists and chemists.

The linkages will help in traceability if something goes wrong as data will be available from the origin to the last point of dispensation, he explained.

The complete ecosystem has to be developed, Swaminathan told *businessline*, pegging the evolution of the track-and-trace journey at 2 on a scale of 10, indicating a

long journey ahead in creating the linkages for traceability or product recalls, especially when it comes to medical devices. Companies that export are aligned to international standards, he said, calling for greater streamlining in the presentation of QR code data in the domestic market as well.

GLOBAL SYSTEMS

India cannot work in silos, said Swaminathan, adding that aligning with internationally recognised systems will ensure that the product, batch and expiry information are encoded in a universal manner.

"This strengthens patient safety, builds consumer confidence and ensures that every stakeholder in the pharmaceutical supply chain benefits from transparency and interoperability," he said.

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